

PYROGNOSIS

Fire, the Dark Ground, and the Custody of Witness in the Works of Cormac McCarthy

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A dissertation on the core philosophies of Cormac McCarthy, their originators, and their kin in speculative and philosophical fiction

29 SEPTEMBER 2026

This ordered world, the same for all, no god and no man made; it always was, and is, and will be: an ever-living fire, kindling in measures and going out in measures.

HERACLITUS, DK B30

The sun also ariseth, and the sun goeth down, and hasteth to his place where he arose.

ECCLESIASTES 1:5

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the fiction, drama, and late essayistic work of Cormac McCarthy (1933–2023) constitute a single cosmology whose master figure is fire, and whose governing epistemic operation I term *pyrognosis*: knowledge obtained by submitting a thing to fire and reading what the fire discloses. The term is borrowed deliberately from nineteenth-century mineralogy, in which "pyrognostic" characters were the behaviours of a mineral under the blowpipe, and it is made to bear three further valences: the Heraclitean doctrine of an ever-living, self-exchanging, and judging fire; the Gnostic doctrine of a pneumatic spark exiled in matter; and the Promethean-technological fire that culminates, within the corpus, in the Trinity detonation of 16 July 1945.

Against the four dominant critical paradigms—the nihilist (Bell), the Gnostic (Daugherty, Mundik), the sacramental (Potts), and the naturalist-historicist (Phillips, Sepich)—I contend that each correctly isolates one principle of the McCarthyan cosmos while misrecognizing the relation among them, and that this relation becomes legible only when fire is read simultaneously as ontological substance, epistemic medium, and ethical stake.

The argument proceeds in four movements. Part One reconstructs the genealogy of the McCarthyan fire: Heraclitus's fragments on war, exchange, and a fire that judges (DK B53, B90, B66); Anaximander's "ordinance of time," compressed by the Valéry epigraph of *Blood Meridian* into two words, blood and time; Jacob Boehme's theosophy of the dark and light fires, whose inaugural treatise, *Morgenröte im Aufgang* (1612)—rendered by John Sparrow in 1656 as the "Morning-Rednesse in the Rising of the Sun" and the dawning "in the Orient"—stands, I demonstrate, in point-for-point antithesis to the subtitle *the Evening Redness in the West*; Nietzsche's great noon and Spengler's *Abendland*, which complete a solar ouroboros inscribed in that title; and Schelling's theory of evil as the self-will of the dark ground. Part Two submits the corpus, from *The Orchard Keeper* (1965) through *Stella Maris* (2022) and "The Kekulé Problem" (2017), to sustained exegesis organized by the fire's permutations: orchard, pyre, assay, coin, horn, hearth, and bomb. Part Three situates McCarthy among speculative and philosophical fictions—Dostoevsky, Bulgakov, Lem, Dick, Lindsay, Golding, Dürrenmatt, Vonnegut, Borges, Chiang, Watts, Liu Cixin, Hoban, Miller,

Butler, Beckett, and Camus—by shared problem rather than by influence. Part Four advances the thesis proper.

That thesis holds that the McCarthyan cosmos tends toward *ouroboric closure*—the self-devouring, self-referential, endogamous ring—whose narrative materializations are cannibalism, incest, necrophilia, eternal recurrence, and the proprietary knowledge emblematized by Judge Holden's ledger; and that the corpus opposes to this closure a single counter-motion, the lateral transmission of fire, which I name *custodial witness*: the carrying of a flame one did not kindle and cannot justify, on behalf of a witness who may not exist. I show that the oeuvre is formally bracketed by two ouroboroi—the "outer darkness" of *Outer Dark* (1968), which the Gnostic *Pistis Sophia* identifies with a world-encircling dragon whose tail is in its mouth, and the self-biting serpent of Kekulé's dream, subject of McCarthy's final published essay—and by two narratives of sibling incest, Culla and Rinthy Holme (1968) and Bobby and Alicia Western (2022). The dissertation concludes that McCarthy is neither nihilist nor Gnostic but a pyrognostic custodian, for whom the narrative voice's "optical democracy" is not indifference but a discipline of attention, and for whom the tale itself—together with the reader it conscripts as witness—is the last portable hearth.

Note on Texts, Abbreviations, and Citation

Because McCarthy's works circulate in trade, library, and international editions whose paginations diverge, primary texts are cited by abbreviation and, where precision matters, by chapter, section, or scene rather than by page. Quotation from the primary texts is held to a deliberate minimum: the argument proceeds by paraphrase and by the citation of brief nominal phrases—"optical democracy," "carrying the fire"—that have long since become terms of art in the critical literature. Pre-Socratic fragments are cited by Diels–Kranz (DK) number; translations of the ancient, patristic, and early-modern sources are my own paraphrases unless otherwise indicated. Secondary sources are cited by author and year and listed in the Works Cited.

ABBREVIATION	WORK	FIRST PUBLISHED
OK	*The Orchard Keeper*	1965
OD	*Outer Dark*	1968
CG	*Child of God*	1973
S	*Suttree*	1979
BM	*Blood Meridian, or the Evening Redness in the West*	1985
APH	*All the Pretty Horses*	1992
C	*The Crossing*	1994
TS	*The Stonemason*	1994
GS	*The Gardener's Son* (screenplay)	1996
CP	*Cities of the Plain*	1998
NC	*No Country for Old Men*	2005
R	*The Road*	2006
SL	*The Sunset Limited*	2006

ABBREVIATION	WORK	FIRST PUBLISHED
TC	*The Counselor* (screenplay)	2013
KP	"The Kekulé Problem," *Nautilus*	2017
P	*The Passenger*	2022
SM	*Stella Maris*	2022

Three orders of relation between McCarthy and the thinkers adduced are distinguished throughout. *Documented* relations rest on epigraph, title, explicit allusion, or avowal: Boehme and Valéry (BM), Yeats (NC), Melville, Faulkner, and Dostoevsky (Woodward 1992), the King James Bible, Samuel Chamberlain (BM), Gödel, Cantor, Grothendieck, and Wittgenstein (SM), and Kekulé (KP). *Probable* relations rest on dense structural correspondence with sources in wide circulation: Heraclitus, Nietzsche, Spengler, Hobbes, and the modern scholarship on Gnosticism. *Constellational* relations claim no influence at all; they position McCarthy against thinkers whose concepts illuminate his by adjacency—Schelling, Simone Weil, Jean-Pierre Vernant, Lévi-Strauss, Carl Schmitt, John Archibald Wheeler, Quentin Meillassoux, among others. The distinction is maintained so that the boldness of the synthesis never masquerades as a claim about McCarthy's library.

INTRODUCTION

The Problem of the Fire

Cormac McCarthy's work poses, with an insistence unmatched in postwar American letters, one question in many registers: in a cosmos constituted by strife and indifferent to human valuation, what can be carried, and by whom, and for whose sake? The question is literalized in the most quoted exchange of *The Road*, in which a dying father assures his son that they are carrying the fire; it is anticipated a year earlier in the closing dream of *No Country for Old Men*, where a dead father rides ahead into the cold bearing fire in a horn; it is inverted in *Blood Meridian*, where a judge who is also a mineralogist, a paleontologist, and a maker of gunpowder resolves that nothing shall exist outside his knowledge and consent; and it is carried to its most abstract pitch in *The Passenger* and *Stella Maris*, where the children of a physicist who helped build the atomic bomb inherit a fire that began as pure number. This dissertation names that question the problem of the fire and argues that McCarthy's answer, assembled across six decades, amounts to a coherent metaphysics.

I. *The Critical Impasse*

The critical reception of McCarthy has organized itself around four paradigms, each of which isolates a genuine principle of the work and mistakes it for the whole.

The *nihilist* paradigm was inaugurated by Vereen Bell's *The Achievement of Cormac McCarthy* (1988), the first monograph on the author, which read the Appalachian novels and *Blood Meridian* as radically anti-metaphysical: worlds whose events are unmoored from motive, whose characters lack interiority, and whose vitality is the vitality of surface. Bell's reading was contested almost at once—Edwin T. Arnold's "Naming, Knowing and Nothingness" (in Arnold and Luce 1999) insisted on a moral substratum of parable—but it survives, in popular and some academic reception, as the default account of *Blood Meridian* and *No Country for Old Men*.

The *Gnostic* paradigm begins with Leo Daugherty's "Gravers False and True: *Blood Meridian* as Gnostic Tragedy" (1992; in Arnold and Luce 1999), which read Judge Holden as an archon, one of the demonic rulers of a cosmos-prison, and

the kid as the bearer of a pneumatic spark he can neither understand nor extinguish. Dianne C. Luce (2009) extended Gnostic analysis to *Outer Dark* and *The Crossing*; Petra Mundik's *A Bloody and Barbarous God* (2016) systematized it across the corpus; Harold Bloom supplied its widest frame by arguing, in *The American Religion* (1992), that American religiosity is itself a post-Christian Gnosis, and by canonizing *Blood Meridian*, in *How to Read and Why* (2000), as the major American novel since Faulkner.

The *sacramental* paradigm, given its fullest form in Matthew L. Potts's *Cormac McCarthy and the Signs of Sacrament* (2015), locates meaning not in doctrine but in gesture—the shared meal, the washed body, the burial of the dead—arguing that McCarthy's moral seriousness consists in rites performed without metaphysical guarantee. Allied readings treat *The Road* as a grail narrative (Cooper 2011) or its boy as a Christ-figure.

The *naturalist-historicist* paradigm, articulated with polemical force by Dana Phillips (1996), resists allegory altogether: *Blood Meridian* is a naturalist chronicle whose landscape refuses the anthropocentric hierarchy, and whose violence is a fact of the species rather than a symbol of anything. Its archival arm—John Sepich's *Notes on Blood Meridian* (1993; rev. 2008), John Cant's study of American exceptionalism (2008)—has reconstructed the historical matrix of the scalp trade and the borderlands with philological exactitude.

Each paradigm is right about one thing. The nihilist is right that the McCarthyan cosmos has no ground: nothing underwrites value. The Gnostic is right that the cosmos is experienced as exile and that something in certain characters—a clemency, a refusal—behaves like a foreign spark. The sacramentalist is right that meaning survives as enacted gesture rather than stated belief. The naturalist is right that the narrating voice levels the hierarchy of beings. But each is embarrassed by what the others see. The nihilist cannot account for the novels' obsessive staging of acts of care. The Gnostic cannot account for the fact that the spark is never returned to a pleroma, never saved by a knowledge from outside. The sacramentalist cannot account for the absence of any instituting church or efficacious grace. The naturalist cannot account for the relentless moral testing to which the fiction submits its characters. What is missing is the medium in which these four principles relate. I submit that the medium is fire.

II. *Thesis*

The dissertation defends five linked propositions.

1. *Ontology.* Being in McCarthy is fire in the Heraclitean and Boehmean sense: a self-kindling and self-quenching process whose law is strife and whose medium is exchange. Violence is therefore ontological before it is moral; it is the grammar of the cosmos, not an aberration within it.
2. *Anthropology.* Consciousness and language are a late ember within an archaic dark ground. McCarthy made this explicit in "The Kekulé Problem," which describes the unconscious as an ancient biological system for running an animal and language as a recent invention that entered the brain like an invader, which the unconscious still declines to use—preferring to speak, as it did to the dozing Kekulé, in images.
3. *Epistemology.* To know is to assay by fire, and knowing bifurcates. In its *proprietary* mode—the ledger, the specimen, the scalp, the bomb—the knower becomes sovereign, and knowledge becomes the condition of the known thing's permission to exist. In its *custodial* mode—the tale, the burial, the carried ember—the knower keeps what he cannot own.
4. *Structure.* The cosmos tends toward *ouroboric closure*: the ring that devours its own tail. Cannibalism, incest, necrophilia, eternal recurrence, and self-reference are its narrative forms, and the oeuvre is formally bracketed by two ouroboroi (*Outer Dark* and "The Kekulé Problem") and two incests (the Holmes and the Westerns).
5. *Ethics.* The only non-sovereign relation to fire is *custodial witness*: the transmission of a flame one did not kindle and cannot justify, carried laterally—outward, exogamously, as Greek colonists carried fire from the common hearth of the mother city to kindle the hearth of the new—rather than hoarded. Its final vessel is the tale, and its final custodian the reader.

The name for the whole is *pyrognosis*. In the mineralogy of the nineteenth century—the science the judge practises with his hammer—pyrognostic tests identified a substance by its behaviour in flame: its fusibility, its colour, its intumescence or decrepitation. McCarthy's fiction is pyrognostic in precisely this sense. It exposes persons, communities, and doctrines to extremity and records what melts, what flares, and what persists.

III. *Method: Constellation and Assay*

The method is double. It is, first, *constellational*, in the sense Walter Benjamin gave the word in the epistemo-critical prologue to his study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928): ideas stand to phenomena as constellations to stars, arrangements that make particulars legible without subsuming them. The sources assembled here are coordinates as much as origins. McCarthy himself licensed such reading when he told Richard Woodward (1992) that books are made out of books—that the novel lives on the novels that preceded it—and his four decades at the Santa Fe Institute, among physicists, complexity theorists, and students of the origins of language, license the treatment of scientific concepts as intrinsic to the work rather than as external glosses.

The method is, second, an *assay*. Each chapter submits a text to a particular fire—a philosophical or theological frame—and records what burns off and what remains. The procedure is falsifiable in the only way literary argument can be: a frame that consumes the text without residue, or that leaves it unchanged, has failed the test.

IV. *Architecture of the Argument*

Part One (Chapters 1–4) reconstructs the genealogy of the McCarthyan fire: the pre-Socratic cosmos of strife and exchange; the solar ouroboros encoded in the title of *Blood Meridian* by way of Boehme, Nietzsche, and Spengler; the dark ground of Gnostic, Schellingian, and apophatic theology; and the literary lineage and prose style through which these inheritances become form. Part Two (Chapters 5–10) conducts the assay novel by novel, from the Tennessee period to the late diptych and "The Kekulé Problem." Part Three (Chapter 11) places McCarthy among speculative and philosophical fictions grouped by problem: apocalypse and transmission; the hallucinated or demonic visitor; chance and fate; the children of the bomb; pre-linguistic mind; Gnostic fantasy; and cosmic indifference. Part Four (Chapter 12) states the thesis systematically, meets the strongest objections, and draws the consequences for how McCarthy should be read.

I

PART ONE

Genealogies of Fire

DAWN



CHAPTER 1 *The Ever-Living Fire*

CHAPTER 2 *Morning-Redness and Evening-Land*

CHAPTER 3 *The Dark Ground*

CHAPTER 4 *Books Made Out of Books*

CHAPTER 1

The Ever-Living Fire: Heraclitus, Anaximander, and the Judicial Cosmos

McCarthy's ontology is pre-Socratic before it is Christian. Its first principle is not a creator but a process—fire, strife, exchange—and its first law is not love but measure enforced by penalty. This chapter reconstructs that ontology from the Ionian and Sicilian fragments and shows that Judge Holden's notorious doctrines, far from being idiosyncratic villainy, are a nearly systematic anthropomorphization of Heraclitus.

1.1 A Kosmos No One Made

Heraclitus's fragment B30 holds that this ordered world, the same for all beings, was made by no god and no man, but always was, is, and will be an ever-living fire, kindled in measures and quenched in measures. Three features of the fragment govern the McCarthyan cosmos. First, it is *uncreated*: there is no demiurge whose intentions could be interrogated or whose goodness could be impeached, which is why theodicy in McCarthy always collapses into something older than theodicy. Second, it is *the same for all*: the kosmos confers no privilege on any class of beings. The narrator of *Blood Meridian* names this condition "optical democracy"—a desert light in which a man enjoys no more standing than a stone—and the phrase is, I submit, the most exact modern paraphrase of B30's *ton auton hapantōn*. Third, the fire is *measured*: it kindles and quenches according to proportion, so that destruction is not the cosmos failing but the cosmos keeping time.

1.2 *Fire as Universal Equivalent*

Fragment B90 supplies the economics of this cosmos: all things are exchanged for fire and fire for all things, as goods for gold and gold for goods. Heraclitus reached for money to describe ontology; McCarthy reverses the figure and reaches for ontology to describe money. Every major McCarthyan economy is a Heraclitean exchange in which fire, blood, and currency are fungible. In *Blood Meridian* the governments of Chihuahua and Sonora pay silver for scalps, converting persons into tokens at a fixed rate; the Glanton gang's descent from bounty hunting to the scalping of peaceable Mexicans and Tigua villagers follows the logic of any universal equivalent, which cannot tell one head of hair from another. In *No Country for Old Men* a satchel of drug money draws every character into its orbit, and Chigurh's coin, whose authority he derives from its long circulation, makes the exchange-principle itself the arbiter of life. In *The Counselor* a cartel economy converts desire, grief, and bodies into shipment and loss. In *The Passenger* Bobby Western is a salvage diver—a man whose profession is to recover value from the deep in exchange for a share of it.

Marx called money the universal equivalent, the commodity in which every other commodity expresses its value; Alfred Sohn-Rethel argued that the abstraction performed in exchange precedes and conditions the abstractions of philosophy. McCarthy's economies stage this "real abstraction" as a combustion. The scalp is the purest instance: a part of a person, severed so that the person may be counted, then counted so that the person may be paid for. Exchange consumes its object as fire does.

1.3 *War, Father of All*

Fragments B53 and B80 make war the father and king of all things, the power that shows some as gods and others as men and makes some slaves and others free; war is what is common, justice is strife, and all things come to pass by strife and necessity. Holden's campfire theology in *Blood Meridian* is a nearly verbatim gloss. War, he argues, preceded humanity and awaited it, a trade prepared in advance for its practitioner; war is the ultimate game because the stakes are the players themselves; war forces existence into unity; war, in the three words that have become the novel's signature, is god. The judge's deduction is rigorous on Heraclitean premises: if all things come to be through strife, then war is not the corruption of the logos but its most legible manifestation, and the man who gives himself wholly to war participates in the cosmos's self-disclosure.

Fragment B52 completes the portrait. Lifetime, *aiōn*, is a child at play moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child. Holden holds that men are born for games and that every child knows play to be nobler than work. The

Heraclitean child-king is split, in *Blood Meridian*, into two figures: the player who treats war as the supreme game, and the child whom the novel's first two words command the reader to see. The kid is the child whom the game is played upon, and the novel's question is whether he will become a player.

1.4 *The Fire That Judges*

Fragment B66, preserved by Hippolytus in his *Refutation of All Heresies* (IX.10.6), holds that fire, coming upon all things, will judge and seize them. Its authenticity is disputed; many editors hear in it a Stoic doctrine of cosmic conflagration retrojected onto Heraclitus. Its provenance matters less here than its afterlife, for the fragment transmits to the Christian and early-modern West the image of a *judicial fire*, a burning that is also a verdict. McCarthy's judge is B66 given a body. Holden comes upon all things—stones, fossils, birds, peoples, languages—and judges them by entering them in a ledger, after which he frequently destroys the original. His vow that whatever exists without his knowledge exists without his consent is the claim of a fire that has a right of seizure over everything it touches.

Fragment B94 joins the judge to the title. The sun will not overstep its measures, Heraclitus says; if it does, the Erinyes, the ministers of Justice, will find it out. The meridian is the sun's measure at its height. A *blood* meridian is a zenith at which the measure has been overstepped, and the novel's pursuing furies—the Yuma, the desert, the judge himself as a retributive dikē—arrive accordingly.

1.5 *Anaximander and the Ordinance of Time*

The oldest surviving sentence of Western philosophy, Anaximander's fragment preserved by Simplicius, holds that things return into that from which they arose, as is necessary, for they pay penalty and retribution to one another for their injustice according to the ordinance of time. The Valéry epigraph of *Blood Meridian* ends by compressing this sentence into two nouns: blood and time. Penalty is blood; ordinance is time. Nietzsche, in *Philosophy in the Tragic Age of the Greeks* (1873), read Anaximander as the first pessimist, for whom individuated existence is itself a guilt to be expiated by perishing. Heidegger opened "The Anaximander Fragment" (1946) by asking whether we, the latecomers, stand at the evening of the land of evening, the *Abend-land*.

Both readings converge on *Blood Meridian*. The judge enforces an Anaximandrian penalty upon all beings for the injustice of existing apart from him; the kid, born in the year of the Leonid storm, pays for the injustice of having come to be at all; and the novel's subtitle, as the next chapter shows, places the whole in the Heideggerian evening-land.

1.6 *Empedocles on the Volcano*

Empedocles set two cosmic powers, Love and Strife, to alternate in dominion over the four roots. McCarthy's world lies under Strife, but Love survives as residue: in the boy of *The Road*, in Billy Parham's custody of a wolf, in the Western siblings' doomed attachment. The legend that Empedocles leapt into Etna gave Gaston Bachelard, in *The Psychoanalysis of Fire* (1938), the name for a reverie in which love and death are fused in flame—the Empedocles complex.

Blood Meridian contains an inverted Empedocles. In the tale told by the ex-priest Tobin, the judge leads a powderless gang to a volcano, gathers niter from a bat cave and sulphur from the crater, and has the men urinate upon the mixture to make gunpowder. He does not die in the mountain; he extracts from it the means of death for others, transmuting excrement into fire in an operation whose alchemical overtones—the *nigredo*, the base matter raised to power—are unmistakable. The scene is the judge's origin myth as a Promethean technician: the man who knows how fire is made from the earth's refuse.

1.7 *Ekpyrosis and Recurrence*

The Stoics systematized the Heraclitean fire into a cosmology of periodic conflagration, *ekpyrosis*, followed by regeneration, *palingenesis*, repeated without end. *The Road* is McCarthy's ekpyrosis: a world burned to ash after a long shear of light, with no assurance of palingenesis beyond a boy and a remembered trout. Nietzsche's eternal recurrence secularizes the Stoic cycle, and the judge's closing claim that he will never die is its parody: not the joyful affirmation of return but the persistence of a principle that outlives every instance.

1.8 *Ontological Violence*

McCarthy told Woodward (1992) that there is no such thing as life without bloodshed, and that the idea of a perfectible species living in harmony is a dangerous one. Critics have read the remark as misanthropy. Read against the fragments, it is ontology: violence belongs to the measure by which the kosmos kindles and quenches itself. But ontology does not settle ethics. If the cosmos is fire, the question is not whether one will be burned but what one will do with the flame. The rest of this dissertation is an answer to that question.

CHAPTER 2

Morning-Redness and Evening-Land: The Solar Ouroboros of a Title

The full title of McCarthy's fifth novel—*Blood Meridian, or the Evening Redness in the West*—is a compressed philosophy of history. This chapter argues that it answers, term for term, the title of the first book by the mystic whom McCarthy placed among its epigraphs; that its first half names Nietzsche's great noon and its second Spengler's evening-land; and that the novel, read against this title, traces a complete solar day that closes into a ring.

2.1 The Disjunctive Subtitle

The "or" subtitle is a nineteenth-century convention, and McCarthy's use of it places his book in a determinate company: *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818), the founding modern fable of stolen fire, and *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale* (1851), the American epic of whiteness and pursuit. Both precursors are relevant. The judge is a Promethean technician and an Ahab-like totalizer; his hairless pallor, as critics since Bloom have noted, recalls the whale whose whiteness Ishmael found more appalling than any colour. The subtitle, however, points elsewhere as well.

2.2 Boehme's Morning-Redness

Jacob Boehme (1575–1624), the shoemaker of Görlitz, composed his first treatise in 1612 under the title *Aurora, oder Morgenröte im Aufgang*. When John Sparrow published the English translation in 1656, he rendered the title as *Aurora*, the day-spring or dawning of the day in the Orient, or "Morning-Rednesse in the Rising of the Sun." Set Sparrow's title beside McCarthy's subtitle and the correspondence is exact and inverted:

BOEHME, AURORA (SPARROW, 1656)	MCCARTHY, BLOOD MERIDIAN (1985)
Morning	Evening

BOEHME, AURORA (SPARROW, 1656)	MCCARTHY, BLOOD MERIDIAN (1985)
Redness (*Röte*)	Redness
in the Rising of the Sun	[the setting implied]
in the Orient	in the West

Since McCarthy chose a passage from Boehme as one of the novel's three epigraphs, I submit that the inversion is not coincidence but citation. *Blood Meridian* is an anti-*Aurora*: where Boehme narrated the dawning of divine light out of the dark ground, McCarthy narrates the setting of that light into the ground again.

The content of Boehme's theosophy sharpens the point. Beneath God lies the *Ungrund*, the groundless abyss of will without object. From it the divine life generates itself through seven source-spirits (*Quellgeister*): astringency, bitterness, and anguish constitute a dark, contracting wheel; the fourth spirit is fire, the flash (*Blitz*) or terror-crack (*Schrack*) in which the anguished dark either breaks through into the light and love of the fifth spirit or recoils into wrath. From this generation emerge three principles: a dark world of wrath-fire, a light world of love-fire, and the outward, visible world in which the two are mixed. The fire is one; its principles are two. God, as Deuteronomy and Hebrews say, is a consuming fire, and Boehme's whole speculation is an attempt to say how the same fire can be wrath and love.

The epigraph McCarthy chose expresses the doctrine of the first principle. It holds, in paraphrase, that the life of darkness is not sunk in misery, that there is no sorrowing there, because sorrow is swallowed up in death, and death and dying are themselves the life of the darkness. The dark world, that is, possesses its own vitality, a vitality of consumption. *Blood Meridian* is set almost entirely within Boehme's first principle: a world of wrath-fire in which the flash that might transmute wrath into love occurs, if at all, only as flicker—the kid's unaccountable clemency.

The Boehmean flash recurs across the corpus as a structural event. Jimmy Blevins in *All the Pretty Horses* flees the lightning that has killed his kin; Magdalena's epileptic seizures in *Cities of the Plain* are the *Blitz* in the flesh, the falling sickness that the ancients called sacred; *The Road* begins its catastrophe with a long shear of light; *The Crossing* ends with the Trinity flash. In each case the flash is the Boehmean turning point, and in each case the question is which fire it will release.

2.3 *Nietzsche's Great Noon*

Nietzsche titled his 1881 book of aphorisms *Morgenröte*, reviving Boehme's word. Two years later he opened *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* with the prophet addressing the sun and resolving to go under (*untergehen*) as the sun goes under in the evening. At the close of the first part he names the hour toward which the teaching moves: the great noon (*der große Mittag*), when humanity stands midway between beast and overman and celebrates its way toward evening as its highest hope, since that way leads to a new morning.

A meridian is a noon. McCarthy's title thus fuses the two halves of Zarathustra's solar vocabulary: the zenith ("Meridian") and the going-under ("Evening Redness"). The judge is a Zarathustrian parody. He dances, he laughs, he is light on his feet despite his bulk, he affirms everything that is, and he proclaims that he will never die. But where Zarathustra's noon is the hour of self-overcoming, the blood meridian is the zenith of a will that overcomes only others. The kid, for his part, occupies the position Zarathustra assigns to humanity—a rope or bridge over an abyss—and the novel's bleakest judgment may be that the bridge does not bear weight.

2.4 *Spengler's Evening-Land*

Oswald Spengler's *Der Untergang des Abendlandes* (1918–1922) treats cultures as organisms with seasons, and the West as a "Faustian" culture whose soul reaches toward infinite space: perspective painting, the calculus, the telescope, the long-range gun. In its late phase a culture hardens into *civilization*, a world-city culture of money and technique ruled at last by Caesars. The German *Abendland*, evening-land, is the ordinary word for the Occident; "the Evening Redness in the West" is very nearly a translation of it, sunset-coloured.

The judge speaks Spenglerian morphology. Among the Anasazi ruins he lectures on the vanished builders whose works stand as an indictment of those who come after, and throughout he treats peoples as rising and falling forms. The Glanton gang is a Caesarist band of condottieri operating in the vacuum left by the Mexican War, and the novel's geography is Faustian: an infinite westward horizon that terminates at the Colorado River crossing and the Pacific shore. Heidegger's gloss on the *Abend-land*, cited in Chapter 1, completes the lineage: the West as the land in which Being enters its evening.

2.5 *A Day That Closes into a Ring*

Read against its title, *Blood Meridian* describes a single solar day. The kid is born in 1833, the year the Leonid meteors fell in such numbers that the night seemed to be ending—a birth at midnight among falling stars. The narrative reaches its meridian in the killing seasons of 1849–1850 in Chihuahua and Sonora. It reaches evening at the western edge of the continent: the massacre at the Yuma crossing, the flight across the desert, the jail in San Diego. And then the epilogue opens, famously, at dawn, with a man advancing over the plain by the holes he strikes into the ground, raising fire out of rock. Boehme's morning-redness returns—but as the fire of the post-hole digger, the spark of enclosure, the first mark of the fences that will close the open country.



Figure 1. The solar ouroboros of Blood Meridian. *The narrative day runs from the Leonid night of 1833 through the meridian of 1849–50 and the western evening of 1850 into the night of 1878, and ends at the dawn of the epilogue, where the serpent's head meets its tail.*

The day, in other words, is an ouroboros. Ecclesiastes had already said it: the sun also ariseth, and the sun goeth down, and hasteth to his place where he arose. McCarthy's novel does not escape this solar ring; it enacts it, and its final dawn is the beginning of a new enclosure rather than a redemption.

The later corpus extends the figure. *The Crossing* ends in July 1945 in the Jornada del Muerto, where a light rises in the desert before the true sunrise: the Faustian West has manufactured its own dawn, the radiance that Oppenheimer recalled from the *Bhagavad Gita* as a thousand suns rising together. *The Sunset Limited* names the westbound train toward which a despairing professor walks. The evening redness in the West, first a metaphor of decline, becomes at Trinity a literal fire.

2.6 *From Heliotrope to Pyrotrope*

In "White Mythology" (1971) Derrida argued that Western metaphysics is a heliology: its governing metaphors turn around the sun, the source of light that makes seeing and knowing possible, and philosophy forgets that its concepts are worn-out solar figures. McCarthy's West, I submit, performs the substitution that Derrida's argument anticipates. The heliotrope becomes a *pyrotrope*: the sun, sovereign source of visibility, is replaced by man-made fire—the campfire where the judge lectures, the gunpowder, the burning hulks of *The Road*, the atomic flash. The rest of Part One asks what theology can survive that substitution.

CHAPTER 3

The Dark Ground: Gnosis, Schelling, and the Apophatic Remainder

McCarthy retains the topology of Gnosticism—exile, spark, archon, prison—while withholding its soteriology. The result is a Gnosticism without gnosis, in which the spark is not returned upward to a pleroma but passed laterally, hand to hand. This chapter establishes that claim through three bodies of thought: ancient Gnosis and its modern interpreters, Schelling's metaphysics of the dark ground, and the apophatic tradition.

3.1 *The Gnostic Grammar and Its Modern Hinge*

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) gave the twentieth century its canonical grammar of Gnosis: an alien God beyond the cosmos; a demiurge and his archons who rule the world as jailers through fate (*heimarmenē*); a divine spark (*pneuma*) fallen into matter and stupefied by it; a call from outside; and a saving knowledge that awakens the spark to its origin. Jonas's epilogue, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism," argued that modern nihilism is a Gnosticism from which the transcendent God has been subtracted: the cosmos remains alien and indifferent, the self remains thrown and exiled, but there is no longer anywhere to return to.

Jonas's epilogue is the hinge on which the McCarthy criticism turns without knowing it. Bell's nihilist reading and Daugherty's Gnostic reading are not opposed accounts but two moments of Jonas's single thesis: the Gnostic moment, in which the cosmos is a prison with an outside, and the nihilist moment, in which the outside has vanished and only the prison remains. The critical impasse described in the Introduction dissolves once it is seen that McCarthy stands precisely at Jonas's hinge—and then does something neither moment predicts.

Daugherty (1992) read the judge as an archon and the kid as a pneumatic whose spark manifests as refusal. Mundik (2016) extended the analysis to the whole corpus, tracing the demiurgic structure of *The Crossing* and the archontic violence of *No Country for Old Men*. Bloom, whose *The American Religion* (1992)

diagnosed a native American Gnosticism centred on a self older than creation, and whose *Omens of Millennium* (1996) avowed his own Gnostic sympathies, supplied the widest frame: McCarthy as the novelist of the American religion in its darkest register.

3.2 *Outer Dark and the Serpent of the Pistis Sophia*

McCarthy's second novel takes its title from the Gospel of Matthew, where the unprofitable are cast into outer darkness, and there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth (Matthew 8:12, 22:13, 25:30). The phrase has a second, Gnostic afterlife. The *Pistis Sophia*, a third- or fourth-century Coptic treatise preserved in the Askew Codex and translated into English by G. R. S. Mead, describes the outer darkness as a great dragon whose tail is in its mouth, lying outside the whole world and encircling it, and containing within itself the places of punishment.

In Gnostic cosmography, then, the outer darkness *is* the ouroboros. McCarthy's 1968 title names, knowingly or not, the self-devouring serpent that encircles the prison-world; his final published essay, "The Kekulé Problem" (2017), takes as its central exhibit the serpent that seized its own tail in the dream of August Kekulé. The career is bracketed by the ouroboros. This is the first of the formal brackets on which the dissertation's structural thesis rests.

The novel's action fits the frame. Culla Holme fathers a child upon his sister Rinthy, abandons it in the woods, and lies about its death; a tinker takes the infant; Rinthy wanders in search of it, her breasts still leaking milk long after the birth, so that her body continues the custody her brother refused. Through the landscape move three nameless men—a grim triune—who interrogate, pronounce, and execute, a travelling tribunal whose bearded leader is the first sketch of Judge Holden. Their number parodies the Trinity; in retrospect it also anticipates the Trinity of 1945, the Oppenheimer code name that would end *The Crossing*. At the close the triune kills the tinker and confronts Culla with the child; when Culla disowns it, their bearded leader cuts the infant's throat and the mute among them feeds on the body, while Culla looks on and does nothing. Culla, last seen, stands where a road dissolves into a swamp as a blind man walks past him toward it. The dead-end road and the sightless walker complete the figure: a world whose paths terminate in matter, traversed by witnesses who cannot see.

3.3 *Schelling: Evil as the Self-Will of the Ground*

The Boehmean dark fire passed into German Idealism chiefly through Schelling, who read Boehme with Franz von Baader and built his *Philosophical Investigations into the Essence of Human Freedom* (1809) upon Boehme's distinction of principles. Schelling distinguishes in God the *ground* of existence from God as *existing*. The ground is a dark longing, a will that wills nothing determinate, the irreducible remainder (*der nie aufgehende Rest*) that never dissolves into understanding. In God, ground and existence are bound together by love. In the human being they are separable, and this separability is the condition of freedom for good and evil.

From this Schelling derives a theory of evil that breaks with the Augustinian tradition. Evil is not a privation, a mere absence of good; it is positive. It arises when the self-will (*Eigenwille*) of the ground, which should serve as the dark basis of the universal will, elevates itself above the universal will and seeks to become the whole. Evil is therefore spiritual rather than sensuous: only spirit can invert the order of principles, and the most spiritual beings can be the most evil.

Judge Holden is the most exact literary embodiment of Schellingian evil that I know. His vow that whatever exists without his knowledge exists without his consent is the particular will's usurpation of the universal: the ground, which in Boehme and Schelling is the dark condition of all things, claiming to be their sovereign. His erudition—law, geology, paleontology, languages, music, dance—confirms Schelling's insight that evil is not bestial appetite but the inversion of spirit. The Augustinian reading of the judge as an absence, a void where a person should be, is precisely wrong: he is the fullest presence in the novel. Through the Boehme epigraph, *Blood Meridian* cites the fountainhead of the very metaphysics its villain enacts.

3.4 *The Apophatic Remainder*

Against the judge's total knowledge stands the tradition that holds the highest truth to be unknowable. Pseudo-Dionysius, in the *Mystical Theology*, directed the soul into a darkness beyond light; Meister Eckhart distinguished God from the Godhead and located the latter in a silent desert where no distinction has ever looked; the anonymous *Cloud of Unknowing* taught that God is reached by love and never by thought. Christopher Metress (2001) read *Outer Dark* as a narrative of this *via negativa*.

McCarthy's deserts are, among other things, Eckhartian. Their emptiness is not merely the absence of God but the only site in which a God who exceeds every name could be encountered, and his characters' theology is correspondingly apophatic. In *The Road* the father curses and challenges an

unanswering God in the ash; the old wanderer who calls himself Ely declares, in a paradox the tradition would recognize, that there is no God and that he and his companions are that God's prophets. In *The Crossing* an ex-priest concludes that acts have their being in the witness and that God alone is the adequate witness—an apophatic theology of testimony to which Chapter 7 returns. Apophasis is the counter-principle to the ledger: it holds that what is highest is precisely what cannot be entered.

3.5 *The Sacramental Counter-Reading*

Potts (2015) reads McCarthy through sacramental theology: meaning is enacted in signs that effect what they signify, above all in the shared meal and the care of bodies. *The Road* abounds in such signs—the father washing a dead man's blood and brains from his son's hair, which he declares to be his task; the meals of tinned food shared in firelight; the boy's insistence on burying or blessing the dead. McCarthy's Catholic formation, in a Knoxville parish and at the city's Catholic high school, gives the reading biographical plausibility.

The sacramental reading perceives correctly that meaning in McCarthy is enacted rather than asserted. It errs in presupposing institution and efficacy: a sacrament requires a church to authorize it and a grace to make it work, and McCarthy supplies neither. What his characters perform are rites without a church—gestures whose efficacy is nowhere guaranteed and whose only warrant is that they are carried on. I call such rites *sub-sacramental*, and I will argue in Chapter 8 that their proper patron is not the Christ of the altar but Hestia of the hearth.

3.6 *Gnosticism without Gnosis*

We can now state the chapter's conclusion. McCarthy keeps the Gnostic topology: the world is experienced as prison and exile, it is governed by archontic figures of law and fate (the triune, the judge, Chigurh), and certain characters bear something that behaves like a spark—a clemency, a refusal, an unaccountable tenderness. What he withholds is gnosis. No messenger arrives; no saving knowledge is conferred; no pleroma awaits. The spark therefore cannot go up. It can only go across: from father to son, from the dead to the living, from teller to listener. Jonas's modern nihilism is Gnosticism minus God. McCarthy's cosmos is Gnosticism minus gnosis, plus custody. The spark's only destination is another hand.

CHAPTER 4

Books Made Out of Books: The Literary Lineage and the Pyrognostic Style

McCarthy's prose is the instrument through which the metaphysics of the preceding chapters becomes experience. This chapter traces the avowed literary lineage and then argues that the style itself is pyrognostic: a single, impartial flame to which every object is submitted, alternating with a second register—dialogue—that functions as a hearth.

4.1 *The Avowed Canon*

In his 1992 interview with Richard Woodward, McCarthy made three declarations that govern any account of his sources. He said that books are made out of books, that the novel depends for its life on the novels already written. He named Melville, Dostoevsky, and Faulkner as the writers he admired. And he professed incomprehension of writers—Proust and Henry James among them—who do not deal with issues of life and death. The canon is therefore one of extremity: novels that test their persons in the fire.

4.2 *The King James Bible*

The deepest stratum is the Authorized Version. McCarthy's syntax—parataxis, polysyndeton, the long chain of clauses joined by "and"—is the syntax of Hebrew narrative as the King James translators rendered it, a syntax that refuses subordination and therefore refuses to rank events by causal or moral importance. Ecclesiastes lends the corpus its cyclical sun and its sense that one generation passes and another comes while the earth abides; Job lends it the unanswered complaint; Revelation lends *The Road* its apocalyptic frame, including, as critics have observed, the possible resonance between the hour at which the clocks stop (1:17) and the verse in which the Son of Man lays his hand on the terrified seer and names himself the first and the last (Revelation 1:17).

4.3 *Melville*

Moby-Dick is the model in three respects. Ishmael's meditation on the whiteness of the whale (chapter 42), in which whiteness becomes the visible form of an annihilating blankness, underwrites Holden's hairless pallor. Ahab's address to the corposants in "The Candles" (chapter 119), where he defies and adores the clear spirit of clear fire he once worshipped as a Persian, is the literary archetype of the McCarthyan relation to fire as rival sovereign. And "The Try-Works" (chapter 96) provides the corpus with its pyrognostic warning: Ishmael, dozing at the helm while the rendering fires rage, turns to face the blaze, nearly capsizes the ship, and concludes that a man must not look too long into the face of the fire, which inverts and deadens.

Billy Budd supplies Claggart, whose evil Melville defines, after Plato, as depravity according to nature—an evil without cause or history, which is exactly what readers encounter in Holden and Chigurh. *The Confidence-Man* supplies the shape-shifting talker, the swindler-philosopher, who returns as Long John Sheddan in *The Passenger* and, transfigured into vaudeville, as the Thalidomide Kid.

4.4 *Dostoevsky*

Dostoevsky gave McCarthy the novel of ideas in which ideas kill. The hallucinated devil who visits Ivan Karamazov in his fever (*The Brothers Karamazov*, Book XI, chapter 9)—shabby, witty, a parasite of the rational mind—is the ancestor of the Kid who visits Alicia Western. The Grand Inquisitor's argument that humanity wants authority, miracle, and mystery rather than freedom recurs in the judge's contempt for moral law and in the cartel Jefe's counsel in *The Counselor*. Kirillov in *Demons*, who reasons his way to suicide as the supreme assertion of self-will, stands behind White in *The Sunset Limited* and, more distantly, behind Alicia. Stavrogin, the charismatic void at the centre of *Demons*, prefigures Holden. And the Underground Man's revolt against the tyranny of two times two is four is the exact inverse of Alicia Western's fidelity to mathematics, which is total and fatal.

4.5 *Faulkner*

Faulkner is the proximate father. *The Orchard Keeper* was edited by Albert Erskine, Faulkner's own editor at Random House, and its layered chronology and regional idiom announce the debt. Three Faulknerian structures recur. The incest plot of *Absalom, Absalom!* and the obsession of Quentin Compson with his sister Caddy in *The Sound and the Fury*, culminating in Quentin's death by water in 1910, return in *Outer Dark* and, sixty years later, in Bobby and Alicia Western. The watch that Quentin's father hands him as a tomb of all hope, and that Quentin breaks on the morning of his death, returns in the clocks of *The Road*, stopped at 1:17. And "The Bear," with its old untameable animal, its wilderness vanishing before the timber company, and its young hunter who learns the animal only to see it destroyed, is the template for Billy Parham's she-wolf in *The Crossing*.

4.6 *Conrad, O'Connor, Joyce, Dante, Shakespeare*

Conrad's Kurtz, whose eloquent report on civilizing the natives ends in a scrawled injunction to exterminate them, is the precursor of the judge, whose learning and slaughter are likewise one; the scalp contracts of *Blood Meridian* are that postscript made policy. Flannery O'Connor's Misfit in "A Good Man Is Hard to Find" (1953)—a roadside killer who reasons about Christ and meaning while his accomplices murder a family—is the direct ancestor of Chigurh. Joyce's *Ulysses* stands behind the urban wanderings of *Suttree*. Dante's descent shapes the katabases of *Suttree*, *The Road*, and *The Passenger*, whose protagonist is a diver who goes down into the dark water for a living. And King Lear on the heath, confronting in Edgar the unaccommodated man, the thing itself, bare and forked, stands behind the father and son on the roads of ash.

4.7 *The Pyrognostic Style*

From these inheritances McCarthy forged a style with six defining features.

1. *Optical democracy.* In the desert of *Blood Meridian* the narrator observes that no object has precedence over any other, that a rock and a man are bequeathed a strange equality. Dana Phillips (1996) made the phrase the key to a naturalist reading; Levi Bryant's *The Democracy of Objects* (2011) and Manuel DeLanda's "flat ontology" later gave the idea philosophical names. I propose a further genealogy. Simone Weil, in "The *Iliad*, or the Poem of Force" (1940–41), located the *Iliad*'s greatness in its equity: its bitterness falls equally on victor and vanquished, and it neither admires force nor hates its victims. McCarthy's optical democracy is Weil's Homeric equity transposed into a narrative optics.

2. *Lexicon as geology.* The prose deploys an archaic, technical, and regional vocabulary—saddlery, geology, botany, borderland Spanish—so that words appear as strata. Emerson, in "The Poet" (1844), called language fossil poetry; McCarthy's diction is that fossil record excavated, each word a mineral submitted to the assay.

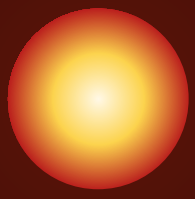
3. *Speech on the same plane as stone.* The suppression of quotation marks, and of the apostrophes of common negative contractions, denies speech an ontological privilege. Voices sound in the landscape as wind and hoof-fall do.

4. *No interiority.* Characters are seen from outside, as acts and gestures. The style is aligned, avant la lettre, with the unconscious of "The Kekulé Problem": meaning arrives as image and act rather than as proposition.

5. *Two registers.* The high descriptive register—what James Wood (2005) called McCarthy's sanguinary sublime, and what B. R. Myers (2001) attacked as portentous—alternates with a laconic vernacular in dialogue that is often tender and frequently funny.

6. *The narrator as assayer.* Like a mineralogist with a blowpipe, the narrative voice submits every object to one flame and records its colour, refusing to rank what it sees.

The two registers correspond to the two fires. The descriptive register is the assaying flame: impartial, cold in its brilliance, pyrognostic in the strict sense. The dialogic register is the hearth: warmth, humour, companionship, the talk of cowboys at a campfire and of a father and son under a tarp. The critical controversy over McCarthy's style, between admirers of the sublime and scoffers at its excess, has overlooked that the style is dual by design. The flame tests; the hearth keeps. The rest of this dissertation will show that the ethics of the corpus lives in the relation between them.



II

PART TWO

The Corpus as Assay

MERIDIAN

CHAPTER 5 *Appalachian Darkness*

CHAPTER 6 *The Great Noon of Blood*

CHAPTER 7 *The Tale and the Witness*

CHAPTER 8 *The Coin and the Horn*

CHAPTER 9 *The Portable Hearth*

CHAPTER 10 *The Cold Light*

CHAPTER 5

Appalachian Darkness: The Tennessee Novels

The four Tennessee novels establish the elementary grammar of the corpus. Each is built around a figure who stands in a determinate relation to what he cannot own—a corpse, a child, a woman, a self—and the four relations form a system: custody without knowledge (*The Orchard Keeper*), refusal of custody (*Outer Dark*), possession as the parody of custody (*Child of God*), and companionship as flight (*Suttree*).

5.1 *The Orchard Keeper*: Custody without Knowledge

The novel's title names its ethic. Arthur Ownby, an old man living alone above the ruined orchard, discovers in a disused insecticide pit the body of a man he does not know—Kenneth Rattner, killed in self-defence by the bootlegger Marion Sylder—and for seven years he keeps watch over it, covering it with cedar and visiting it, without ever learning or asking whose it is. This is the corpus's first act of custodial witness, and its purity lies in its ignorance: Ownby keeps the dead because the dead are there, not because he knows or owns them. The structure is doubled across generations. Sylder befriends the dead man's son, John Wesley Rattner, and neither knows what binds them.

Against this custody the novel sets the state. Ownby fires upon a government tank installed on the mountain—an enigmatic metal structure that critics have associated with the federal presence in the valley—and is taken away to an institution. And against custody it sets exchange. In an episode that anticipates the scalp economy by twenty years, the boy turns in a dead hawk for a county bounty, then returns to buy it back, only to learn that the exchange cannot be undone. The Heraclitean conversion of creature into coin (B90) is here shown as irreversible, and the boy's attempt to reverse it is the novel's moral climax. The elegiac close, in which the narrator lists those who are now gone, fled, or undone, performs the custody of memory that the novel has taught.

5.2 *Outer Dark*: The Closed Hearth

Chapter 3 read *Outer Dark* as Gnostic cosmography; here it is read as anthropology. Claude Lévi-Strauss argued in *The Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949) that the prohibition of incest marks the threshold between nature and culture, because it obliges a group to give its daughters and sisters away and so to enter into exchange with others. Incest is the refusal of that first exchange: a hearth that burns only inward. Culla Holme's union with Rinthy is such a closed hearth, and its consequences unfold with the rigour of a demonstration. The child of the closed hearth is refused by its father, carried off by a pedlar of tin, and finally killed and fed upon by the triune while its father watches. The closed ring feeds on its own product.

Rinthy's persisting lactation is the novel's counter-sign: the body continues a custody the will has abandoned, and she walks the roads in search of a child she will never be allowed to keep. Culla, by contrast, is the man who refuses to witness. He lies about the child's death, flees each scene of violence, and ends at a road that sinks into a bog, watching a blind man walk toward it. The refusal of custody and the refusal of sight are, in McCarthy, the same refusal.

5.3 *Child of God*: Possession as the Parody of Custody

Lester Ballard begins the novel expelled from the hearth: his farm is auctioned from under him, and when he protests he is struck down with an axe. Thereafter the novel is a sequence of anti-hearths. He takes the body of a young woman found dead in a car, sexually violates the corpse, and keeps it, dressing and undressing it and carrying it about; when the fire he builds in his cabin grows out of control the cabin burns with the corpse inside. He then murders to obtain bodies, and retreats into caves, where he stores the corpses of the women he has killed. At a fair he wins stuffed animals with a rifle, collecting effigies of creatures as he later collects effigies of love.

Ballard is the Tennessee sketch of the judge. His necrophilia is proprietary witness in miniature: the reduction of another to a thing that can be possessed because it can no longer refuse. What he keeps is not kept in trust but held as property. The narrator's notorious early address—introducing Ballard as a child of God, much like the reader perhaps—conscripts the reader into the witness the novel demands, and forbids the comfort of holding him at a distance. The coda completes the assay in a colder fire: Ballard's body is delivered to the state medical school, where students open, section, and catalogue it. Science receives what the community expelled, and the novel leaves open whether that reception is custody or a final possession.

5.4 *Suttree: The Huntsman and the Water-Bearer*

Suttree, twenty years in the writing, is McCarthy's largest refusal of the proprietary world. Cornelius Suttree has abandoned his family's wealth and his father's law for a houseboat on the Tennessee River, where he fishes and lives among the outcasts of McAnally Flats: the farcical, indestructible Gene Harrogate; Ab Jones, the Black tavern keeper beaten to death by police; the ragpicker; the mussel-dredging family whose daughter Wanda dies under a rockslide. Suttree owns nothing and keeps company; his ethic is companionship without claim.

The novel's metaphysics is gathered around death and doubling. Suttree was born with a twin who did not survive, and the dead brother haunts him as the self he might have been; in the fever of typhoid he undergoes visions that approach the Dantean. Near the end, a decomposed body found in his house is taken for his own, and Suttree leaves the city as if released from the identity it assigned him. The final images are paired. A boy with a dipper brings him water—custody in its most elementary form, the offering of drink to a stranger. Behind him, a huntsman with hounds moves through the land, and the novel closes with an injunction to flee them. Death is the proprietor of all things; the only answer is to go on, and to accept water when it is offered.

5.5 *The Tennessee Grammar*

The four novels yield four relations to what cannot be owned, and they will recur, transposed, through the rest of the corpus.

NOVEL	FIGURE	RELATION	LATER TRANSPOSITION
The Orchard Keeper	Arthur Ownby	Custody without knowledge	The kid's offer to the long-dead woman (BM); the boy with his father's body (R)
Outer Dark	Culla Holme	Refusal of custody and of sight	Bell's flight in the war (NC); Billy's rejected dog (C)
Child of God	Lester Ballard	Possession as parody of custody	Judge Holden's ledger (BM); Chigurh's instrumentalism (NC)
Suttree	Cornelius Suttree	Companionship as flight	John Grady and Billy's errantry; the father and son's road (R)

The Tennessee novels also inaugurate the corpus's two figures of closure. Incest (*Outer Dark*) and necrophilia (*Child of God*) are forms of the same ring: love turned back upon itself, toward the same blood or toward the dead. Against them

stand the orchard keeper's vigil and the water-bearer's dipper. Everything that follows elaborates this opposition on a larger stage.

CHAPTER 6

The Great Noon of Blood: Blood Meridian

Blood Meridian stages the war between two witnesses: the judge, whose knowing is proprietary and ends in the annihilation of the known, and the narrating voice, whose optical democracy is a custodial witnessing of all things equally. The kid stands between them, and the novel's tragedy is that the only witness the judge cannot tolerate is the one who might carry something out of the fire.

6.1 *History and Its Refusal*

The novel is anchored in the historical record with an exactitude that John Sepich's annotations have made plain. Its principal source is Samuel Chamberlain's *My Confession*, the memoir of a young dragoon who claimed to have ridden with John Joel Glanton's scalp hunters and who described among them an enormous, hairless, learned man called Judge Holden. The Glanton gang contracted with the government of Chihuahua in 1849 to take Apache scalps at a bounty; it proceeded, as bounty economies do, from Apache camps attacked at dawn, women and children among the dead, to peaceable Mexicans and Indians whose hair was indistinguishable at the counting table; and it met its end at the Yuma crossing of the Colorado in April 1850, when Quechan warriors, retaliating for the gang's seizure of the crossing and its violence there, killed Glanton and most of his men. Around this core McCarthy arranges the aftermath of the Mexican War, the filibustering of Captain White's expedition into Sonora, the massacre of that expedition by Comanches, and the long retreat across the desert.

Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973) had shown that the American frontier myth imagined violence against the wilderness and its peoples as a renewal of the national spirit. *Blood Meridian* grants the violence and withholds the regeneration. The novel does not refute the myth by argument; it submits it to the assay. What remains after the fire is not a regenerated nation but a line of post holes.

6.2 *See the Child*

The novel's first words are an imperative to witness. The reader is commanded to see a child: fourteen, motherless (his mother died bearing him), son of a drunken schoolmaster who quotes poets, illiterate, and already brooding, the narrator says, over a taste for mindless violence. He is born in 1833, the year of the Leonids, and he is given no name. He is less a character than a site: the place where the reader must decide whether anything in a human being resists the fire.

The evidence is sparse and therefore precious. The kid cuts an arrow from a comrade's leg when others would have left the man to die. He carries a Bible he cannot read. Years later, alone in the desert, he comes upon an old woman kneeling in a niche of rock, tells her he is an American and offers to take her to safety—and discovers that she has been dead for many years, a dried shell. The offer is absurd and it is the novel's purest act: custody extended to the long dead, where nothing can be gained and nothing can be owned. Above all, when he has the judge in his rifle sights in the desert after Yuma, and the ex-priest Tobin urges him to shoot, he does not fire.

The judge supplies the interpretation. Visiting the kid in the San Diego jail, and again at the end, he accuses him of having reserved in his soul a corner of clemency for the heathen; of having sat in judgment on his own deeds; of having been a witness against himself; of having broken with the body to which he was pledged and so poisoned its enterprise. The judge's charge is precise. The kid's crime is not cowardice but *witness*—the retention, within the enterprise, of a standpoint from which the enterprise can be seen and judged. For a sovereign knower, such a standpoint is intolerable.

6.3 *The Judge as Pyrognostic Scientist*

Holden is the novel's scientist. He carries a geologist's hammer and tests the rocks; he identifies fossils and lectures on the antiquity of the earth; he collects specimens of plants, insects, birds, and artefacts, sketches them in his ledger with fine exactness, and then—often—destroys them, scraping a pictograph from the rock after copying it, destroying an artefact after drawing it. Asked by Toadvine why he does this, he explains that he intends to be suzerain of the earth, and that whatever exists without his knowledge exists without his consent. He would have every bird in a cage; the freedom of birds offends him.

The judge belongs to a historical type. The decades of the novel are the decades of the scientific expedition in the Americas. Alexander von Humboldt had surveyed New Spain at the beginning of the century and was publishing *Kosmos* while Glanton rode; Charles Darwin sailed on the *Beagle* in the years around the kid's birth. More darkly, Samuel George Morton published *Crania*

Americana in 1839, a lavishly illustrated catalogue of Native American skulls whose measurements were used to rank the human races, grounding the racial science of the "American School"; Josiah Nott and George Gliddon's *Types of Mankind* (1854) and Louis Agassiz's polygenism extended it, and Nott put it to work in the defence of slavery. I submit that the scalp economy and the skull cabinet are two faces of one epistemic regime, in which the body of the other becomes a specimen to be collected, counted, measured, and entered in a ledger. The judge is the point at which the regime ceases to pretend to be disinterested.

Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno argued in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) that enlightenment is totalitarian: that its reason tolerates nothing that does not submit to calculation, and that Bacon's identification of knowledge with power ends in domination. Michel Foucault, in *The Order of Things* (1966), described the classical natural history of the eighteenth century as a science of the *table*, in which beings are known by their placement in a visible grid. Holden's ledger is that table in the hands of a man who has understood its consequence. To enter a thing in the ledger is to seize it; to destroy the original afterwards is to make the ledger the only place where the thing exists. This is pyrognosis in its proprietary mode: the assay that consumes its sample.

6.4 *The Theology of War*

Chapter 1 traced the judge's doctrine of war to Heraclitus. Its moral corollary has other ancestors. When the judge declares that moral law is an invention of the weak for the disenfranchisement of the strong, and that historical law subverts it at every turn, he speaks as Callicles speaks in Plato's *Gorgias*—conventional justice is the device of the many weak against the few strong—and as Thrasymachus speaks in the first book of the *Republic*—justice is the advantage of the stronger. He anticipates Nietzsche's account, in *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887), of a slave revolt in morals. And his form is Sadean. The libertines of *Philosophy in the Bedroom* and *Juliette* deliver philosophical lectures between atrocities, arguing that nature is destruction and that crime serves her economy of renewal; Holden lectures by the campfire between massacres, and his hearers, like Sade's, are also his accomplices.

The judge's parable of the harnessmaker belongs here: a tale of a murdered traveller and of a son marked by a father he never knew, which the judge glosses as a lesson in how the dead father's absence governs the son as surely as any presence could. The doctrine is one of lineage without custody—transmission by wound rather than by care. It is the exact inverse of what *The Road* will teach.

6.5 *The Idiot and the Parody of Custody*

One episode reveals the judge's relation to custody as parody. The gang acquires an idiot, James Robert, kept in a cage by his brother. When the idiot wanders into a river, the judge wades in and lifts him out, naked and streaming, and thereafter the idiot follows him like a creature that has been adopted. The scene is a baptism inverted: the drowning innocent is rescued not into a community but into ownership. The judge keeps the idiot as he keeps specimens. Custody in the judge's hands is collection.

With children the parody becomes murder. After the gang takes an Apache child, the judge holds and plays with the boy, and soon afterwards kills and scalps him. The novel's first scene shows the judge breaking up a revival by falsely accusing its preacher, before the crowd, of raping an eleven-year-old girl, and then admitting he had never seen the man before; and its insinuations about the judge himself have led many readers to see him as a sexual predator of children, though it never shows such an act. A novel that opens with the command to see the child hands the child to its judge.

6.6 *The Narrator against the Judge*

The decisive opposition in the novel is not between the judge and the kid but between the judge and the narrating voice. In the desert, the narrator observes, all phenomena share a strange equality: no spider, stone, or blade of grass can claim precedence, and a man and a rock enter into unsuspected kinships. Critics have read this optical democracy as the novel's nihilism—an indifference that levels the massacre and the mesa. I read it as the novel's ethics.

Consider what each witness does with the world. The judge enters beings into a ledger in order that nothing shall exist outside his consent; his witnessing ranks, seizes, and destroys. The narrator enters beings into prose in order that each may be seen with the same attention; its witnessing refuses rank and keeps. The judge's knowledge is sovereign; the narrator's is custodial. Simone Weil's account of the *Iliad*—a poem whose equity lets force be seen acting on victor and vanquished alike, and which is thereby the most truthful account of force ever written—describes the narrator of *Blood Meridian* exactly. The flat light is not the absence of care; it is care disciplined out of partiality. The judge wants to be the only witness. The narrator insists that everything be witnessed.

6.7 *The Jakes and the Dance*

In 1878, in a saloon at Fort Griffin, Texas, the kid—now called the man, forty-five years old—meets the judge again. The saloon is a carnival of degradation; a bear dressed as a dancer is shot where it performs. The judge speaks to him of the dance: only the man who has given himself wholly to the blood of war, who has been to the floor of the pit and seen horror whole, can dance; the man who has held back has no place in it. The man goes out to the jakes. The judge is waiting there, naked; he gathers the man into his vast flesh and bolts the door. Two men who later open it recoil from what they see, which the novel does not show. The implication is that the judge kills him there; many readers also take the embrace as a rape.

The witness is killed at the moment of his last refusal, and the scene is withheld from the reader's witness in turn. Then the judge is dancing in the saloon, naked, fiddling, light, huge, saying that he never sleeps and that he will never die. The principle outlives every instance. This is the ouroboric closure in its purest form: the dance of recurrence that consumes whatever might break the circle.

6.8 *The Epilogue: Fire in the Rock*

The epilogue follows on a new page. At dawn a man advances across the plain by means of holes he is making in the ground, driving his two-handled implement into each and striking from the rock within the fire that God has put there. Behind him come wanderers—some searching for bones, some not—who move from hole to hole as if the line of holes were a validation of sequence and causality.

The passage has been read as hope (the divine spark struck from matter, the Gnostic *spinthēr* liberated) and as doom (the post holes of the barbed-wire fences that will close the open range after 1874). I hold that it is both, and that its ambiguity is the novel's conclusion. The fire in the rock is the Boehmean dawn that ends the solar day of Chapter 2; it is also the moment at which the Heraclitean fire enters the ledger of property. Locke derived property from labour mixed with land; Carl Schmitt, in *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950), derived all law from the originary act of appropriating and dividing the ground, the *nomos* whose root means to divide and to pasture. The man of the epilogue is making *nomos*: the fences that will convert the anomic frontier of blood into the legal order of enclosure, and that will render the scalp hunter obsolete by accomplishing his work by other means. Frederick Jackson Turner would announce in 1893 that the frontier had closed. The epilogue shows the closing as

a line of sparks. Whether those sparks are carried as a hearth or fenced as a property is the question the rest of the corpus inherits.

CHAPTER 7

The Tale and the Witness: The Border Trilogy

The Border Trilogy converts the fire into narration. Where *Blood Meridian* opposed two witnesses, the trilogy develops a full theory of witness—what it is to see, to tell, and to keep—and tests it against the two great solvents of the postwar West: the market and the bomb.

7.1 *All the Pretty Horses: The Chivalric Fire*

John Grady Cole, sixteen in 1949, rides into Mexico because the ranch of his dead grandfather has been sold and the world of horses is ending. He is a knight-errant in the line of Don Quixote: his code is anachronistic, his loves are absolute, and the country he rides into punishes both. The novel's fire is the fire of the horse, the animal John Grady loves for the ardour of its blood, and its metaphysics is voiced by Luis, an old veteran of the Revolution, who teaches that horses share a single soul, so that to understand one horse truly would be to understand them all. The doctrine is a species-level version of the medieval Averroist thesis of one intellect shared by all minds, and it is the first appearance in the trilogy of a knowledge that is communal rather than proprietary.

Against it stands Dueña Alfonsa, the hacendado's great-aunt, who tells John Grady the history of her family, of the Madero brothers, and of the Revolution's ruin, and who gives him a philosophy of fate in the image of a puppet show whose strings, traced upward, end in the hands of other puppets, and so without end. Her fatalism is not Chigurh's—she is a woman of feeling who has lost much—but it establishes the trilogy's question: whether a life is authored, and by whom.

The prison at Saltillo supplies the ordeal. John Grady kills the knife-wielding boy sent to murder him, and he carries the killing home as a wound that no court can dress. The novel then sets up the corpus's most significant counter-image to Judge Holden. Back in Texas, a county judge hears John Grady's account of his claim to Blevins's horse, believes him, and releases him; that night the boy visits the judge's house to confess the killing, and the judge, rather than sentencing

him, receives the confession and answers with an avowal of his own unresolved guilt. Where Holden is a judge who ledgers, this is a judge who listens. The two judges bracket the Western as the two forms of witness.

7.2 *The Crossing I: The Wolf and the Uncapturable*

Billy Parham, sixteen on the eve of the Second World War, traps a pregnant she-wolf that has crossed from Mexico into the New Mexico bootheel, and instead of killing her resolves to take her home to the mountains of Mexico. The resolution is the trilogy's purest act of custody: to return a creature to the country of its origin, at great cost, without claim.

The old trapper Don Arnulfo, dying, gives the novel its epistemology. The wolf, he teaches in effect, is like a snowflake: to catch it is to lose it, for what one holds in the hand is no longer what one wished to know. The doctrine is a precise refutation of the judge. Holden's ledger captures in order to know and destroys what it captures; Don Arnulfo's teaching holds that capture *is* destruction, and that the only knowledge of the wolf is the knowledge of a thing allowed to remain free. Proprietary pyrognosis consumes its sample. Custodial pyrognosis lets the fire burn where it is.

The market defeats Billy's custody. The wolf is taken from him and made to fight dogs in a pit at a fair, a spectacle on which men wager. Billy enters the pit and shoots her to end her suffering, then trades his rifle for her body and carries it into the mountains to bury it. The exchange inverts the scalp economy exactly: where Glanton's men took bodies to obtain money, Billy gives up his weapon to obtain a body he can only bury. It is the Heraclitean exchange of B90 run backward—fire surrendered for a creature's dignity.

7.3 *The Crossing II: Three Tales and a Theory of Witness*

The novel is punctuated by three long tales told to Billy by strangers. Together they form a complete theory of witness.

1 *The priest at Caborca.* An ex-priest tells of an anchorite who lost his son to an earthquake and lived thereafter in the damaged church of Caborca, beneath a dome that might fall, conducting a quarrel with God. The priest's conclusion is that acts have their being in the witness; that the world is not a substance but a single tale, of which every particular tale is part; and that God is the only adequate witness to it. This is the ontology of testimony.

2 *The blind man.* A revolutionary blinded in the war teaches, through his own and his wife's telling, that the world is in its own nature dark, and that light belongs not to the world but to the eyes that see it. This is the Boehmean dark ground restated as optics: the world is the first principle, and the light is carried by the witness.

3 *The gypsies and the aeroplane.* A band of gypsies hauling the wreck of an aeroplane down from the mountains tells of rival claims about which of two planes it is, and concludes that the past can be recovered only as a tale whose truth is not in any object. This is the epistemology of history: the witnessed past is irrecoverable except as narration.

The three tales converge on the position this dissertation calls custodial witness. Being requires witness; the witness carries the light rather than finding it in things; and what the witness carries forward is a tale rather than a possession. Boyd Parham, Billy's brother, killed in Mexico, becomes the subject of a corrido; Billy returns years later to exhume his bones and carry them home, and loses them on the road. The tale survives; the bones do not.

7.4 *The Crossing III: The False Dawn*

The novel ends in July 1945. Billy, wandering, drives away a crippled and misshapen dog that has attached itself to him. That night he wakes to a white light rising in the desert before the true dawn—the Trinity detonation in the Jornada del Muerto, the Journey of the Dead Man. After the light has died he calls for the dog he rejected, and it does not come, and he sits down in the road and weeps.

The juxtaposition is the trilogy's most exact moral statement. At the moment the West manufactures its own sun—the proprietary fire of pure physics, knowledge converted into a power over everything—the man who has spent his life in acts of custody commits his one refusal of it, and understands at once what he has done. A persistent, perhaps apocryphal, report holds that a blind girl many miles away perceived the Trinity flash; true or not, the story belongs with the blind man's doctrine. The atomic light is the first light bright enough to be seen by the blind, and it illuminates nothing.

7.5 *Cities of the Plain: Seizure, Knife, and the Dreamer's Map*

In 1952 John Grady and Billy work a ranch near Alamogordo whose land the army is about to take for its weapons ranges: the nomos of the epilogue to *Blood Meridian* has become the fence of the military state. John Grady falls in love with Magdalena, an epileptic prostitute in a Juárez brothel, and resolves to marry her and bring her across the river. Her seizures are the Boehmean flash in the flesh, the sacred disease; his love is the chivalric fire at its most reckless. The pimp Eduardo, who owns her, mocks the American's faith in stories as a boy's romance; he has her killed; and in the knife fight that follows John Grady kills Eduardo and dies of his wounds, carried by Billy through the streets.

The epilogue leaps to 2002. Billy, old and homeless, meets under a highway overpass a stranger who tells him a dream within a dream: a traveller who dreams of a man about to be sacrificed, and whose own life is thereby entangled with the dreamed man's. The stranger's exegesis proposes that a life has a pattern that can be seen only as a whole, as a map is seen once the journey is done, and that every death stands in for others. It is the priest of Caborca's single tale reformulated as a map, and it is offered, like water from a dipper, to a man who has nothing.

7.6 *Custody across Generations*

The trilogy's last pages show Billy taken in by a family whose mother, Betty, tells him that she knows who he is. The closing verse that follows pledges, in paraphrase, a reciprocal custody across the generations: the child held now will hold the elder later, as the world grows cold and the story ends. The verse states in four couplets the ethic this dissertation extracts from six decades of fiction. Custody is not a possession of the other but an exchange of positions across time—the Heraclitean exchange of B90 remade as a gift. The fire that the judge hoards and the bomb concentrates is here passed back and forth between the young and the old, and the tale ends by asking the reader to turn the page.

CHAPTER 8

The Coin and the Horn: No Country for Old Men *and* The Counselor

No Country for Old Men is built on two dreams and a coin. Sheriff Ed Tom Bell's first dream, recounted at the novel's close, is of his dead father giving him money, which he loses; his second is of his father riding ahead into the cold and dark carrying fire in a horn. Between the lost money and the carried fire the novel places Anton Chigurh, whose coin makes exchange itself the arbiter of life. The two dreams are the two economies of fire in their most compressed form.

8.1 *Byzantium Refused*

The title is the first line of Yeats's "Sailing to Byzantium" (1928), in which an aged speaker, a tattered coat upon a stick, abandons the country of the young and the dying generations and sails to the holy city, there to be gathered into the artifice of eternity and remade as a golden bird singing to lords and ladies of what is past, passing, and to come. Bell does not sail. He remains in the country of the dying generations, and his italicized monologues—confessional, rueful, bewildered by the new drug violence—are the voice of an old man who can neither transcend nor understand.

The novel denies him the consolation of nostalgia. His uncle Ellis, crippled by an old gunshot, tells him that what he faces is not new: the country was always hard on people; Bell's great-uncle Mac was shot dead on his own porch in 1879. And Bell carries a secret that forbids him the role of the old lawman betrayed by degenerate times. In the Second World War he was decorated for an action in which, as he confesses to Ellis, he abandoned his position and the wounded men in it when the enemy came. Bell is a keeper who once refused custody—Culla Holme in uniform—and his elegy for a lost order is also a penance.

8.2 *Chigurh: A Genealogy of the Coin*

Chigurh's coin has at least six ancestors, and assembling them reveals what the figure means.

1. *Heraclitus.* Fragment B90 made fire the universal equivalent, exchanged for all things as gold for goods. Chigurh's coin is that equivalent made the judge of persons: a token for which a life may be exchanged at even odds.
2. *Nietzsche, France, Derrida.* In "On Truth and Lie in an Extra-Moral Sense" (1873), Nietzsche called truths metaphors that have worn out and lost their sensuous force, coins that have lost their images and now count only as metal. Anatole France's dialogue on the language of metaphysics (1900) imagined metaphysicians rubbing the images from coins until the effigy vanished; Derrida built "White Mythology" (1971) upon that image. Chigurh tells the gas-station proprietor that his coin has travelled for more than two decades to arrive at this moment: its authority is its circulation. He restores to the worn metaphor of fate its literal, lethal face.
3. *Borges.* In "The Lottery in Babylon" (1941) chance becomes the total institution of a society administered by a Company that may not exist. Chigurh is the Company's agent, or its only proof.
4. *Camus.* The emperor of *Caligula* (1944), after the death of Drusilla, discovers that men die and are not happy, and sets out to teach the lesson by arbitrary executions. Chigurh's killings are likewise pedagogical: he explains to his victims why they must die.
5. *O'Connor.* The Misfit reasons about Christ and meaning while murder is done on his order. Chigurh inherits his theological manner and his roadside venue.
6. *Schmitt and Kant.* Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. Chigurh is a sovereign who outsources the decision to chance and so disowns it, a decisionism without a decider. Yet he is also, grotesquely, Kantian: having told Llewelyn Moss that he would kill Moss's wife if Moss did not surrender the money, he keeps his word after Moss is already dead, killing Moss's wife as though bound by a maxim he had legislated for himself. Autonomy survives in him as pure form, stripped of the formula of humanity.

The novel's decisive reply is given by Carla Jean Moss. Confronted with the coin, she tells Chigurh that the coin has no say, that it is only him. The rejoinder unmasks fate as an alibi, and it does not save her: Chigurh shoots her dead, a woman who had no part in the money, to keep the promise he made to her husband. (The novel and the Coens' film differ on whether she calls the toss; in

both, the killing is his.) In Sartre's terms, Chigurh's coin is bad faith weaponized: a flight from freedom into a facticity he has himself arranged. The novel then subjects its agent of chance to chance. Leaving Carla Jean's house, Chigurh is struck at an intersection by another car; with his arm broken he buys the shirt off a boy's back for a sling, and the boys fall to quarrelling over his money. The Lottery includes its own officials.

8.3 *The Stockyard and the Satchel*

Chigurh's signature weapon is a captive-bolt pistol, the pneumatic device used to stun cattle in the slaughterhouse. Raymond Malewitz (2009) has read the novel's repurposed tools under the heading of "misuse value." The cattle gun's specific resonance is with the industrial abattoir, where living beings are processed at scale; a remark widely but doubtfully attributed to Adorno holds that Auschwitz begins wherever someone looks at a slaughterhouse and thinks: they are only animals. The remark names the Nazi death camps; at Auschwitz alone the Nazi regime murdered about 1.1 million people, nearly a million of them Jews. Chigurh brings the stockyard to persons. *The Road* will extend the figure to its end, in a cellar where human beings are kept as livestock.

Llewelyn Moss enters the machinery through an act of custody. Having found the dead men, the drugs, and the satchel of money in the desert, he takes the money and goes home; but in the night he returns with a jug of water for a dying man he had left in a truck, and it is this return that exposes him to his pursuers. In the world of *No Country*, custody is fatal. The novel does not thereby condemn it. It shows what custody costs in a world organized around the coin.

8.4 *Bell's Horn: The Hestian Fire*

Bell's second dream answers the first. His father passes him on horseback in the mountains at night, carrying fire in a horn as men used to do, and Bell knows that his father is going on ahead to make a fire somewhere out in all that dark and cold, and that when Bell arrives the father will be there. The lost money of the first dream is exchange, which slips through the hand. The carried fire of the second is custody, which goes before.

The image has a precise classical genealogy. Jean-Pierre Vernant, in his essay on Hestia and Hermes (1965), showed that Greek religion expressed space through a polarity: Hestia, goddess of the hearth, the fixed centre of house and city, and Hermes, god of roads, thresholds, and passage. The hearth does not move; the messenger does not rest. Yet the Greeks knew one practice in which the two were joined. When colonists set out to found a new city, they took fire from the common hearth of the mother city's prytaneion and carried it to kindle

the hearth of the new foundation; Irad Malkin (1987) has examined this ritual transmission of sacred fire in Greek colonization. The Roman fire of Vesta, which the Vestals tended and which might never lawfully go out, belongs to the same religion of continuity.

Bell's father is Hestia carried by Hermes: a hearth in motion, going ahead to found a place where the son may arrive. The image is sub-sacramental in the sense defined in Chapter 3—a rite without a church—and it is the hinge between *No Country* and *The Road*, published a year apart, where the same fire will be carried by a father and a son together.

8.5 *The Counselor*: The World One Has Made

The screenplay for *The Counselor* (2013) transposes the coin into the cartel. An unnamed lawyer invests once in a drug shipment and loses everything: the cartel abducts and murders his fiancée, Laura, and sends him a recording implied to show her killing. Its philosophers are three. A diamond dealer in Amsterdam discourses on stones as bearers of an admonition about the mortality of those who wear them—a pyrognostic meditation on carbon perfected by ancient heat and pressure. Malkina, who keeps cheetahs and admires the elegance of their killing, is the cartel world's connoisseur of predation, the judge reborn as a woman of fashion; she ends by predicting a slaughter beyond imagining. And the cartel's Jefe, on the telephone, tells the ruined Counselor that he must accept the world he has made, since the world in which he might correct his mistakes is no longer the world in which he made them.

The Jefe's counsel is Heraclitus again: one cannot step twice into the same river (B91). It is also the corpus's bleakest formulation of the ontology of exchange. Every act converts the world irreversibly into another world, and there is no counter at which the exchange can be refunded—as the boy in *The Orchard Keeper* discovered when he tried to buy back his hawk. The bolito, a motorized wire noose that tightens without mercy once it is set, is the screenplay's emblem of that irreversibility: an automaton of consequence. Against it the screenplay offers nothing but grief, which the Jefe acknowledges as the one thing that cannot be exchanged.

CHAPTER 9

The Portable Hearth: The Road *and* The Sunset Limited

The Road is the corpus's decisive assay. It burns the world down to ash and asks what remains when the ground of every custom, law, and meaning has been consumed. Its answer is a hearth that moves: a fire carried by a father and son whose only warrant is that they carry it. *The Sunset Limited*, published the same year, stages the same question as a debate in a single room and ends by showing the limit of custody—the other's freedom to refuse the fire.

9.1 *Ekpyrosis at 1:17*

The catastrophe is given in a few lines of retrospect: the clocks stop at 1:17 after a long shear of light and a series of low concussions; the man fills the bathtub; his wife, who asks why, is pregnant. McCarthy declined to name the cause. Asked about it in 2009, he said, in substance, that geologists among his Santa Fe Institute colleagues thought it looked like a meteor strike, that it might equally be volcanic or nuclear, and that it did not really matter (Jurgensen 2009). The refusal is methodological. The novel is not a scenario; it is a Stoic ekpyrosis, the conflagration of Chapter 1, stripped of the Stoic guarantee of palingenesis. The world that remains is burned, grey, and cooling. Its enemy is not fire but cold: the sun is a dim disc, the snow falls grey, and every night the question is whether a fire can be made at all. After the conflagration, entropy.

The novel's first page supplies its emblem. The man dreams that he has led the child by lamplight through a cave to a black lake, where a pale creature raises its head from the water—eyeless, translucent, its heart and brain visible through its flesh—swings its head toward the light, and lurches away. The dream inverts Plato's cave. Its inhabitant is not a prisoner mistaking shadows for things but a blind animal of the dark ground, Boehme's first principle given a body, and the light is not the sun outside but a lamp that the man carries in. The whole novel is in the image: a father bearing a small light into a darkness that has its own life and does not want it.

9.2 *Prometheus Inverted: Cooking and Cannibalism*

Hesiod tells how Prometheus, at Mecone, divided the sacrificial ox so that mortals received the meat and the gods the smoke of the bones, and how he stole back in a fennel stalk the fire that Zeus had withheld. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant, in *The Cuisine of Sacrifice among the Greeks* (1979), read the myth as the founding of the human condition: humans are the animals who eat cooked meat in shared sacrifice, standing between the beasts, who eat raw flesh and one another, and the gods, who need not eat at all. Hesiod's *Works and Days* states the law explicitly: Zeus allotted to fish, beasts, and birds the custom of devouring one another, because they have no justice, but gave justice to humankind. Lévi-Strauss's *The Raw and the Cooked* (1964) generalized the opposition into a structural anthropology; Richard Wrangham's *Catching Fire* (2009) returned it to biology, arguing that the control of fire and the cooking of food shaped the very anatomy of the genus *Homo*.

The Road runs anthropogenesis backward. The fire that made the species human now cooks the species. The man and boy watch from hiding as a marching band of cannibals passes with its train of chained slaves, of pregnant women, and of collared and yoked boys whom the novel calls catamites—boys kept for sexual use. They discover a locked cellar in which naked captives are kept alive as provisions and eaten a limb at a time; one has lost both legs, the stumps burned closed. And after they see a pregnant woman pass with three men, they find at the group's abandoned camp a newborn charred on a spit: the pregnant women are kept for their children. Every classical figure of the anti-sacrifice is present—Kronos devouring his children, the banquet of Thyestes, Lycaon turned wolf for serving human flesh—and every one is a figure of the fire turned against its own future. This is ouroboric closure in its most literal form: humanity eating its own tail. Chigurh's cattle gun, which brought the stockyard to persons (Chapter 8), finds its completion in the cellar where persons have become livestock.

The boy's ethics are defined against this inversion with a child's bluntness. He asks, again and again, whether they are still the good guys, and receives the assurance that the good guys would never eat anybody. The distinction is minimal and it is everything: Hesiod's justice, the line between those who cook and share and those who devour one another, reduced to a question a child can ask.

9.3 *Carrying the Fire: Hestia in Motion*

Father and son say to each other that they are carrying the fire, and near the end the father tells the boy that the fire is inside him, that it was always there, and that he can see it. The formula condenses the argument of Chapter 8. Bell's father in *No Country* rode ahead with fire in a horn to kindle a hearth in the dark and cold; here the fire is carried by father and son together, and then entrusted wholly to the son. The cart is a mobile house, the tarpaulin a roof, and each night's fire a hearth rekindled: Vernant's polarity of Hestia and Hermes resolved into a single practice, a centre that travels. The road leads south toward the sea, as the Greek colonists' roads led to the ships that carried the fire of the mother city's prytaneion to a new foundation. The boy is the colonial fire of a city that no longer exists, carried toward a community not yet found.

The corpus's two fires meet in a single object. On the beach the father fires a flare over the dark water for the boy's wonder; later, wounded by an archer, he fires the same flare pistol back in answer. The instrument that makes a festival of light for a child is also a weapon. Pyrognosis admits no pure fire, only fires put to use.

9.4 *The Decay of Names*

The man observes that the world is shrinking to a core of parsible entities and that the names of things are following the things themselves into oblivion: colours, birds, foods, finally the words for the sacred, now idioms without referents. Wittgenstein held that the meaning of a word is its use within a form of life; when the forms of life vanish, the words lose their use before they lose their sound. Heidegger called language the house of being; *The Road* shows that house in ruins. Ashley Kunsa (2009) has argued that the novel's attention to naming also opens the possibility of a renewed language, and the boy's speech—spare, repetitive, organized around a few questions and his reiterated "okay"—is the smallest unit of trust that language can offer.

"The Kekulé Problem" allows a further reading. If language is the late ember and the unconscious the ancient dark ground, then language should be the first thing lost in catastrophe, and dreams should outlast it. That is what the novel shows. Words fail; dreams persist. The man distrusts dreams of the lost world—of his wife, of warmth, of colour—as lures toward death, and holds that the right dreams for a man in peril are dreams of peril. He knows that the unconscious, unlike language, will not lie about the world; it will only tempt him to leave it.

9.5 *The Mother, the Father, and Natality*

The boy is born after the catastrophe; he is natality within ekpyrosis. His mother argues before her death that the family are not survivors but the walking dead of a horror film, that she would take the boy with her if she could, and that her only hope is for nothingness; then she goes out into the dark to die by a flake of obsidian—volcanic glass, the frozen fire of the earth. Her argument restates Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933), in which an over-developed consciousness is humanity's tragic excess and the last messiah preaches that the race should end, and it anticipates David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been*, published the same year as the novel.

The father answers not with argument but with care. His position is Hannah Arendt's: in *The Human Condition* (1958) she held that the miracle that saves the world from ruin is the fact of natality, the birth of new persons capable of beginning. The mother is not refuted. She is outlived, and the novel's structure makes her position the permanent temptation against which custody must be renewed every morning.

9.6 *Ely, the Thief, and the Economy of Clemency*

The old wanderer who calls himself Ely—and later says the name is not his own—is the only character given a name, and the name is prophetic. Elijah is the prophet who did not die, taken up by a chariot of fire, and Malachi names him the herald of the great and dreadful day. McCarthy's Ely declares that there is no God and that he and those like him are God's prophets, and says that when he first saw the boy he thought he himself had died. The boy insists on feeding him. The prophet of the fiery chariot survives on a child's charity.

The thief who steals their cart on the beach receives the father's full severity: made to strip, he is left naked on the road. The boy weeps and pleads until they return to leave his clothes and food, and he tells his father that it is he, the boy, who must worry about everything. The kid's clemency in *Blood Meridian*, a corner of the soul the judge could not forgive, is here the boy's whole vocation. His impulse runs always outward—toward a small boy glimpsed in a ruined town, toward a dog, toward strangers—against the father's logic of suspicion. The father keeps the boy; the boy keeps the father human.

9.7 *Transmission and the Trout*

Dying, the father tells the boy to go on south, to carry the fire, and that they can still talk to each other. The boy stays with the body for three days—the custody of the dead that runs from the orchard keeper's vigil through the kid's offer to the long-dead woman to Billy Parham's burial of the wolf. Then a man with a shotgun comes down the road. The boy's first question to him is whether he is carrying the fire. The stranger, with a wife, a boy, a girl, and a dog, wraps the father's body in a blanket as the boy asks, and takes the boy with them. The woman talks to him about God; he finds it easier to talk to his father; she tells him that is all right, and that the breath of God is his breath still, though it passes from one person to another through all of time.

The fire has left the closed ring of father and son and entered another family. That is transmission in the strict sense: exogamous, lateral, a *pneuma* that goes not up to a pleroma but across, hand to hand, as the Greek colonial fire went from city to city and the Homeric golden chain linked earth to heaven. The ouroboros opens into a catena.

Then the coda. Once, the narrator says, there were brook trout in the mountain streams, and on their backs were vermiculate patterns that were maps of the world in its becoming—maps of something that could not be put back or made right again—and in the deep glens where they lived all things were older than man and hummed of mystery. The narrator speaks from an impossible vantage, after the human, of a world before it. Quentin Meillassoux, in *After Finitude* (2006), called statements about realities anterior to all human givenness "ancestral"; the trout are McCarthy's ancestral archive, fossils of a becoming no witness attended. The coda does not promise restoration. It says only that the maps existed. Custody of what cannot be restored is memory, and the novel ends by keeping it.

9.8 *The Sunset Limited: Two Men and a Train*

McCarthy called *The Sunset Limited* a novel in dramatic form. In a tenement room in New York, Black, an ex-convict whose conversion followed an act of violence in prison, has literally caught White, a professor who tried to throw himself before a train. The play is custody made spatial: Black holds White in his room, feeds him, and argues for his life. White's case is the mother's case given a professor's erudition. The culture he loved was always frail; the world, he says in effect, is a forced-labour camp from which innocent workers are taken by lottery, a few each day, to be executed—Borges's Babylonian lottery again, now as metaphysics. Behind him stand Kirillov's logical suicide, the question Camus called the one serious philosophical problem, and the long tradition of the theological dialogue from Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* (1779) to Dostoevsky's "The Dream of a Ridiculous Man" (1877), in which a suicidal man is turned back by the memory of a child he had spurned.

White leaves. Black, alone, asks God whether that is all right, and pledges to go on if he is wanted to. The play's title names the train toward which White walks, and the name completes the solar argument of Chapter 2: the Sunset Limited, a westbound line that has never served New York, is the evening redness in the West converted into a timetable. The anomaly is the point; the train is an allegory. *The Sunset Limited* thus marks the boundary of the ethic *The Road* defines. Custody can carry the fire, and can hold a stranger at the edge of the platform, but it cannot compel another to take the flame.

CHAPTER 10

The Cold Light: The Passenger, Stella Maris, *and "The Kekulé Problem"*

The late diptych relocates the fire to its most abstract source. The Western siblings are the children of a physicist who helped build the atomic bomb, and their story traces the fire backward from its hottest form, fission, to its coldest, number. The discovery of McCarthy's last phase is that the purest light of the mind begets the most terrible fire of the world, and that the mind which lives nearest that light may choose the cold rather than carry it. "The Kekulé Problem," published five years before the novels, supplies their key.

10.1 *Children of Trinity*

The siblings' father worked with Oppenheimer on the bomb; their mother worked at Oak Ridge, where uranium was enriched; the children grew up partly in their grandmother's house in Wartburg, Tennessee, in the hills west of the enrichment plants. The family is thus constituted around the Promethean fire in its terminal form. The father is the corpus's last proprietary knower—not a scalp hunter but a theoretician whose knowledge was converted into sovereign power over every city on earth, and was used: in August 1945 the United States destroyed Hiroshima and Nagasaki with atomic bombs, killing well over a hundred thousand people, most of them civilians, by the end of that year. The children inherit not his knowledge but its guilt. Bobby studied physics and abandoned it; Alicia studied mathematics and could not abandon it. Each lives in the shadow of a fire lit before their birth, as the West lived after the false dawn that ends *The Crossing*.

10.2 *Alicia's Number*

Stella Maris consists entirely of transcribed sessions between Alicia Western, twenty years old, and a psychiatrist, Dr. Michael Cohen, at a facility in Black River Falls, Wisconsin, in the autumn of 1972. She has arrived with tens of thousands of dollars in cash in a plastic bag. She was admitted to the University of Chicago at thirteen, studied in France in the orbit of Alexander Grothendieck, and carries a diagnosis she disputes. The dialogues range across mathematical Platonism, Gödel, Cantor, Grothendieck, Wittgenstein, the foundations of quantum mechanics, the nature of the unconscious, her hallucinations, and her love for her brother.

Alicia is a Platonist: she holds that mathematical objects exist independently of the minds that discover them, as Gödel held. Gödel's incompleteness theorems (1931) showed that any consistent formal system rich enough for arithmetic contains truths it cannot prove, and cannot prove its own consistency from within; the proof turns on a sentence that, in effect, speaks of itself—the logical ouroboros. Douglas Hofstadter, in *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979) and *I Am a Strange Loop* (2007), made such self-reference the model of consciousness itself. Alicia's tragedy may be stated in these terms: she is a mind that cannot ground itself from within, and knows it.

The mathematicians she invokes compose a genealogy of the cold light and its cost. Georg Cantor, who proved that infinities come in sizes, was repeatedly hospitalized and died in a sanatorium in 1918. Gödel, convinced he would be poisoned, starved to death in 1978. Grothendieck, perhaps the greatest mathematician of the century, abandoned the institutions of mathematics, withdrew in 1991 to a village in the Pyrenees, and in *La Clef des songes* (c. 1987) wrote of dreams as messages from God, whom he called the Dreamer. Henri Poincaré (1908) and Jacques Hadamard (1945) had described mathematical discovery as the work of an unconscious that labours unseen and delivers its results suddenly, as an illumination stepping onto an omnibus. The line runs from the unconscious as mathematician to the unconscious as God to the unconscious as the ancient machine of "The Kekulé Problem."

Alicia chooses the cold. At Christmastide 1972, believing that her brother, comatose after a racing accident in Europe, will never recover, she hangs herself in the winter woods, dressed so that she will be found against the snow. The refusal is threefold: of the father's fire, which she will not carry forward; of the libidinal fire, which burns toward her brother and cannot be carried outward; and of the procreative fire, since she leaves no child. Robert Frost set the alternatives in 1920: some say the world will end in fire, some say in ice. The corpus contains both—the Trinity flash and the ash of *The Road* on one side; the

cold of *The Road*, the dark and cold into which Bell's father rides, and Alicia's snow on the other. Alicia is the corpus's only character who chooses ice.

10.3 *The Kid*

Since early adolescence Alicia has been visited by the Thalidomide Kid: a small, bald, scarred figure with flippers for hands, the congenital deformity caused by the sedative prescribed to pregnant women in the years around 1960, attended by a troupe of vaudevillian grotesques. He speaks in patter—puns, non sequiturs, wisecracks, mock-erudition—and his motives remain opaque: tormentor, guardian, or both. In the clinical frame he is a hallucination. In the frame of "The Kekulé Problem" he is an emissary of the unconscious, which does not speak in propositions but in images and, when forced into speech, in the rhetoric Freud analysed in *Jokes and Their Relation to the Unconscious* (1905): condensation, displacement, the pun. The Kid bears in his body the signature of a pharmaceutical catastrophe, as the siblings bear in their history the signature of a nuclear one. He is the unconscious deformed by the techno-scientific age, and still, absurdly, talking. Chapter 11 places him in his literary lineage: Boethius's Philosophy, Ivan Karamazov's devil, Woland's retinue, Lem's visitors, Dürrenmatt's King Solomon.

10.4 *The Diver and the Missing Passenger*

The Passenger opens with Alicia's body in the snow and moves to New Orleans in 1980, where Bobby Western works as a salvage diver. He descends to a small private jet sunk in the Gulf: the dead passengers are still belted in their seats, the flight recorder is gone, and the manifest suggests that one passenger is missing. Afterwards men who present themselves as government agents question him; his accounts are frozen and his papers taken; a colleague dies; Bobby flees. The mystery is never resolved. Kafka's *The Trial* (1925), in which an accusation is pursued without ever being stated, and Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966), in which a conspiracy neither resolves nor dissolves, are the proximate forms. The missing passenger is an empty centre: the witness who was there and is not.

The diver's profession is itself a figure. Bobby descends into dark water and returns with nothing, as the analysand descends into the unconscious and returns with images he cannot read. His life is a series of absences at the decisive hour: he left physics; he was in a coma when his sister needed him; he wakes to find her dead. He survives as a bereaved custodian, a keeper of memory who keeps what he could not save. His conversations with the con man Long John Sheddan, a Melvillean confidence-man, and with the investigator Kline circle the

history of physics and the secret state, never arriving. What Bobby carries is not a fire but its absence, and the novel's question is whether that, too, can be carried.

10.5 *The Closed Hearth Returns*

The late diptych closes the formal ring of the corpus. McCarthy's second novel concerned incest between a brother and a sister; his last two concern a brother and sister bound by a love that is acknowledged and not consummated. Chapter 5 read incest, after Lévi-Strauss, as the closed hearth—the refusal of the first exchange by which culture begins. In *Outer Dark* the closed hearth produces a child who is consumed. In the diptych it produces no child at all. The ring has become sterile. What survives is the transcript—the tale—whose only descendant is its reader. The career that began in the outer darkness that the *Pistis Sophia* calls a serpent with its tail in its mouth ends with a brother and sister who cannot carry their fire outward, and with an essay about a serpent seizing its own tail.

10.6 *The Kekulé Key*

"The Kekulé Problem" appeared in *Nautilus* in April 2017, introduced by David Krakauer of the Santa Fe Institute. Its claims, in paraphrase, are these. The unconscious is a biological operating system, a machine for running an animal, vastly older than language and possessed by all animals. Language is recent—McCarthy suggests on the order of a hundred thousand years—and was probably invented once and spread, taking up residence in brains that had not evolved for it, like an invader the unconscious has never fully accepted. Its founding insight was that one thing could stand for another. And the unconscious still prefers not to use it. When August Kekulé, by his own account at the Berlin *Benzolfest* of 1890, turned his chair to the fire and dozed, and saw a snake seize its own tail, and woke with the ring structure of benzene, the unconscious had solved his problem and delivered the answer as a picture. Why, McCarthy asks, did it not simply tell him? Because it does not speak. Historians of chemistry have questioned Kekulé's story, but its truth as a report of the chemist's life matters less than its truth as a parable of mind.

The essay converges with Terrence Deacon's *The Symbolic Species* (1997), which described language as a quasi-parasitic system that evolved to be learned by children's brains, and with Julian Jaynes's account (1976) of the voices of the gods; it implicitly dissents from nativist accounts of a language organ. For this dissertation its significance is threefold.

1. *It confirms the anthropology of Part One.* The unconscious is Boehme's dark ground, the first principle whose life is not sorrowing; the epigraph of *Blood Meridian* and the essay of 2017 describe the same darkness from opposite ends of a career. Language is the late ember, the Promethean fire that entered the brain from outside.

2. *It relocates the hearth.* Kekulé dreamed by the fire. The unconscious spoke at the hearth, in images, to a man at rest—exactly the conditions under which, the anthropologist Polly Wiessner (2014) found, human beings tell stories. The first custodian of the fire is the unconscious itself, which carried the solution across the dark to the sleeper.

3. *It closes and opens the ring.* The ouroboros is the image of closure; yet it was the image of closure that solved the problem of the ring. The alchemical *Chrysopoeia* attributed to Cleopatra inscribes within its tail-devouring serpent the words *hen to pan*, "the all is one"—a formula Heraclitus would have recognized. The career ends where it began, with the Heraclitean unity of all things and the serpent that encircles the world. But the essay adds what the novels could only enact: that to see the ring is already to stand, for a moment, outside it.

The late phase thus yields its law. Number, the coldest light, produced fission, the hottest fire. Alicia, nearest the light, chooses the cold. Bobby keeps a memory he cannot redeem. And the Kid—the unconscious in motley—keeps talking after reason has fallen silent. The fire of the image outlasts the fire of the proof.

III

PART THREE

Comparative Pyrologies

EVENING

CHAPTER 11 *McCarthy among the Speculative and Philosophical Fictions*

CHAPTER 11

McCarthy among the Speculative and Philosophical Fictions

McCarthy is rarely shelved with speculative fiction, yet *The Road* is a post-apocalyptic novel, *Blood Meridian* an alternative theology of history, and the late diptych a fiction of the physicists' century. This chapter is constellational in the sense defined in the Introduction: it claims no influence, but sets McCarthy beside works that confront the same problems, so that each illuminates the other. Seven problems organize the comparison.

A. *After the Fire: Apocalypse and Transmission*

The post-apocalyptic tradition asks what should be carried out of the ruin. Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826), the first secular end of humanity, closes with Lionel Verney, sole survivor of the plague, setting out by sea with a few books in search of anyone at all: transmission addressed to no one. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) makes transmission its whole subject. Monks preserve the scientific "Memorabilia" through a dark age after the Flame Deluge; civilization is rebuilt from their archive; and the rebuilt civilization rediscovers the bomb and burns again, while a remnant flees on a starship. Miller's history is Spenglerian, and its lesson is that the Promethean fire, faithfully preserved, repeats its catastrophe. McCarthy's boy carries no Memorabilia. He carries the Hestian fire of care, which is the one thing the monks' archive could not transmit.

Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980) is the nearest formal kin to *The Road*. Two thousand years after nuclear war, English has decayed into a phonetic dialect that is also a fossil record; the myth of "Eusa" encodes the splitting of the atom; and the plot turns on the rediscovery of gunpowder, the "1 Littl 1," which kills its chief seeker. Hoban's decayed language is the future of the man's fading names; his gunpowder is the judge's volcano recipe returning at the end of history; and Riddley's final vocation, travelling with a puppet show, anticipates the Kid's vaudeville troupe as a form in which a ruined culture carries its truths as performance.

Octavia E. Butler's *Parable of the Sower* (1993) sends its heroine north along a burning California highway with a growing band of strangers. Lauren Olamina suffers from "hyperempathy," a condition that makes her feel others' pain—the boy's ethic made neurological—and she founds a faith, Earthseed, whose central tenet is that God is Change. Earthseed is a Heraclitean theology. Butler divinizes the flux that McCarthy only fears and endures; where she builds a community by doctrine, McCarthy's boy joins one by trust. Emily St. John Mandel's *Station Eleven* (2014), whose travelling players paint on their caravan the motto that survival is insufficient, argues that art is what must be carried; it is the aesthetic version of carrying the fire. And Beckett's *Endgame* (1957), set in a last room after an unnamed catastrophe, ends in stalemate, but not before Clov, at the window, reports a small boy outside—a possible beginning that Hamm dismisses. *The Road* is, among other things, the novel that follows that small boy.

B. *The Visitor: Demonic and Hallucinated Interlocutors*

The Thalidomide Kid belongs to a lineage of visitors who come to the imprisoned or overreaching mind. In Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), Philosophy appears to the condemned philosopher as a woman of uncertain stature, sometimes of human height and sometimes touching the heavens, and consoles him with reason. The Kid is an anti-Philosophia: small, deformed, mocking, visiting a prisoner of an institution not to console but to needle, and to keep her talking. In *The Brothers Karamazov* the devil who visits Ivan in brain fever is a shabby gentleman, witty, parasitic, and uncertain even of his own reality; Ivan insists he is a hallucination, and the devil is happy to agree. The Kid shares his manner and his ontological coyness.

Mikhail Bulgakov's *The Master and Margarita* (written 1928–40; published 1966–67) supplies the troupe. Woland, a foreign professor of black magic, arrives in Moscow with a retinue of grotesques—a choirmaster, a giant cat, a fanged assassin—and stages a séance of black magic at the Variety Theatre. The Kid's minstrels are Woland's retinue shrunk to a psychiatric ward. Woland is also a counter-Holden. Where the judge destroys originals after copying them, Woland restores the Master's novel, which its author had burned, with the declaration that manuscripts do not burn. That sentence is the aesthetic creed of custodial witness: the tale is the one thing the fire cannot consume.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) supplies the ontology of the visitor. The planet's ocean, which never communicates in language, sends the scientists "visitors" made from their own memories; Kris Kelvin receives a replica of his wife, who had killed herself after he left her, and cannot send her away. The ocean is an unconscious that thinks in materialized images, which is precisely what "The

Kekulé Problem" says the unconscious does; Kelvin's guilt over a suicide is Bobby Western's. Philip K. Dick's VALIS (1981) supplies the theophany: Horselover Fat, struck by a beam of pink light, concludes that the Roman Empire never ended and that the world is a Black Iron Prison—a Gnostic reading of history with which the judge's deathless dance agrees. Dick's lifelong fixation on his twin sister, who died in infancy, rhymes with Suttree's dead twin and with the Westerns' fatal sibling bond.

Friedrich Dürrenmatt's *Die Physiker* (1962) is the most exact analogue of *Stella Maris*. The physicist Möbius hides in a private sanatorium, claiming that King Solomon appears to him, in order to keep his discoveries from being turned into weapons; two fellow patients who call themselves Newton and Einstein are agents of rival powers; and the asylum's director, who has secretly copied his manuscripts, reveals that she means to rule the world. Alicia, too, is a mathematician in an institution visited by an apparition, pursued (in *The Passenger*) by agents, and haunted by the weaponization of her father's science. Dürrenmatt treats madness as a refuge from the proprietary fire; McCarthy asks whether any refuge exists. Julian Jaynes's claim (1976) that the gods of antiquity were hallucinated voices from the brain's other hemisphere supplies the theory in which the Kid is a demoted god.

c. *The Coin of Fate: Chance, Determinism, Decision*

Borges is McCarthy's nearest metaphysical cousin. "The Lottery in Babylon" (1941), discussed in Chapter 8, is Chigurh's political theology. "Funes the Memorious" (1942), about a man who forgets nothing and therefore cannot think, since thought requires abstraction, is the judge's ledger taken to its end: a total record that abolishes understanding. "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines an idealist world in which things duplicate when sought and fade when forgotten; it is the logic of the fading names in *The Road* and of the priest of Caborca's doctrine that acts have their being in the witness.

Ted Chiang's fiction poses McCarthy's questions with a physicist's precision. In "Story of Your Life" (1998) a linguist who learns an alien language that perceives time whole knows that her daughter will die young, and chooses to bear her: natality with foreknowledge, which is the father's condition in *The Road*. The story's appeal to the variational principles of physics, which describe a path as if its end were known in advance, is the respectable cousin of Chigurh's talk of the path his victims chose. "What's Expected of Us" (2005) imagines a device that proves free will illusory and asks the reader to act as though it were not—Carla Jean's refusal of the coin, universalized. "Hell Is the Absence of God" (2001), in

which angelic visitations kill and heal at random like weather, is the theology of Blevins's lightning.

Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) gives determinism its Tralfamadorian form—all moments exist at once, and of every death one can only say that so it goes—and gives the corpus a remarkable rhyme. Billy Pilgrim survives the British and American firebombing of Dresden in February 1945, which killed some 25,000 people; Billy Parham witnesses the Trinity flash in July 1945. Two American Billys stand as witnesses to the two great fires with which the West ended its war. Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919), whose apparatus inscribes the sentence on the condemned man's body until it malfunctions and kills its own officer, is the model for the judge's inscriptions, for the cartel's bolito, and for the accident that befalls Chigurh.

D. *The Children of Trinity: Physicists, Fathers, and the Bomb*

Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) is the direct precursor of the Western siblings. Felix Hoenikker, one of the "fathers" of the atomic bomb, leaves his three children a chip each of ice-nine, a substance that freezes water at room temperature, and their inheritance ends the world when it reaches the sea. The children of the bomb-maker, bearing their father's invention as a curse, are the Westerns; and Vonnegut's apocalypse, notably, is not fire but ice. Frost's alternatives return: the father's fire, the children's cold.

Lem's *His Master's Voice* (1968), narrated by a mathematician recruited to a secret project in the American desert to decode a signal from space, turns on the discovery that the message might yield a weapon, and on the scientists' moral paralysis before the state that funds them. It is *The Passenger*'s theme in the form of a philosophical novel. Don DeLillo's *Ratner's Star* (1976) sends a fourteen-year-old mathematical prodigy to decipher an alien signal, a satirical double of Alicia Western at thirteen. Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) gives the war economy its theology in the V-2 rocket and gives paranoia its canonical form; the agents who pursue Bobby Western are Pynchon's "They" without the jokes. Against all these McCarthy's distinction is his refusal of irony. Vonnegut and Pynchon survive the bomb by laughing; McCarthy grants the laughter only to the Kid.

E. *The Picture before the Word: Pre-Linguistic Minds*

William Golding's *The Inheritors* (1955) narrates the extinction of a band of Neanderthals by the "new people," *Homo sapiens*, from the inside of Neanderthal minds that think not in propositions but in pictures, which they share with one another as images. Only in the last chapter does the viewpoint shift to the newcomers, with their language, their weapons, and their fear. The novel is "The Kekulé Problem" dramatized: the image-mind annihilated by the word-mind. The third epigraph of *Blood Meridian*, reporting that a fossil skull some three hundred thousand years old from Ethiopia had been scalped, extends the same deep time to violence. Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954), with its boys reverting to the hunt, is the kid's island.

J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) imagines a flooded, overheated earth in which human minds regress, through what a character calls "archaeopsychic" time, into the reptilian memory of the Triassic; its hero goes south at the end toward the burning sun, into the past of the species. The archaic unconscious, the drowned world, the diver: Ballard's novel is the dream of Bobby Western's profession. Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), published the same year as *The Road*, argues through its alien "scramblers" that intelligence has no need of consciousness, which may be an evolutionary accident or a handicap; its vampire commander, a resurrected predator of superior intellect, is the judge as hard science fiction. Walker Percy, a Southern Catholic novelist and McCarthy's near contemporary, devoted *The Message in the Bottle* (1975) to the mystery of naming, taking Helen Keller's discovery at the well-house as the paradigm of the symbolic leap. Percy saw in that leap the mark of the spirit; McCarthy, forty years later, saw an invasion. The two answers to the same question divide the Southern metaphysical tradition.

F. *The Alien Fire: Gnostic Fantasy from Lindsay to Dick*

David Lindsay's *A Voyage to Arcturus* (1920) is the great Gnostic fiction in English. Its hero, Maskull, crosses the planet Tormance through a sequence of worlds of pleasure and power, all of them the traps of Crystalman, a demiurge whose vulgar grin appears on the faces of the dead. Beyond them lies Muspel, the true world, named for the Norse realm of fire. In the final chapter Maskull's double, Nightspore, climbs a tower and discovers that Muspel is not an all-conquering light but a fire besieged by Crystalman's world, which must be fought for. Harold Bloom rewrote Lindsay's novel as his own Gnostic fantasy, *The Flight to Lucifer* (1979), before becoming the most influential champion of *Blood Meridian*. The constellation is exact: the critic who canonized McCarthy had himself written a novel about a true fire hidden behind a false world.

McCarthy both belongs to and breaks this lineage. With Lindsay he holds that the true fire is small and endangered; unlike Lindsay he does not locate it elsewhere. The fire is not in Muspel but in a boy on a road, and it is not fought for but carried. Dick's *VALIS*, which ends with the hope of a saviour born as a child, sits between them.

G. *The World without Us: Cosmic Indifference and the Dark Forest*

H. P. Lovecraft's cosmicism begins "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) with the observation that the mind's inability to correlate all its contents is the most merciful thing in the world. *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) sends explorers into the ruined Antarctic city of the "Old Ones," pre-human builders whose remains dwarf and indict their discoverers. The judge's lecture among the Anasazi ruins—the name commonly glossed as "ancient ones"—is Lovecraft's expedition in the Southwest. Olaf Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937) ends with a creator who contemplates the agonies of his creatures with the detached appreciation of an artist; the judge's aesthetics of war and the narrator's optical democracy are, respectively, the malign and the equitable versions of that gaze.

Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008) derives a cosmic sociology from two axioms—that survival is the primary need of civilization, and that civilizations grow while the matter of the universe does not—and concludes that every civilization is an armed hunter in a dark forest, obliged by the "chain of suspicion" to destroy any other it detects. *The Road* is the dark forest on a human scale: every stranger may be a cannibal, and the father's ethic is the chain of suspicion. The boy's repeated insistence on helping strangers is the refusal of Liu's axiom, and the novel's ending, in which a stranger with a shotgun turns out to be carrying the fire, is its falsification.

Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) sets a biologist in Area X, where a sentence written in living fungus grows down the wall of a subterranean tower and the self dissolves into landscape. Its living script is the judge's ledger inverted: writing not as seizure but as growth. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) names the world-without-us that the trout coda glimpses. Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933) and Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010) give pessimism its philosophical form, and their argument that consciousness is a tragic excess is the argument of the mother in *The Road*, of White, and of Alicia.

Conclusion to Part Three

The comparison fixes McCarthy's position. With the pessimists he shares the diagnosis: consciousness is late, the world indifferent. With the Gnostics he shares the topology: the world is a prison, and something in it is foreign. With the post-apocalyptic tradition he shares the question of what should be carried. With Borges and Chiang he shares the metaphysics of witness and fate. His answer is nonetheless his own. He does not escape the world, like Lindsay; he does not divinize its flux, like Butler; he does not laugh, like Vonnegut and Pynchon; he does not preserve its Promethean knowledge, like Miller's monks. He carries a fire that belongs to no one.

IV

PART FOUR

Pyrognosis

NIGHT



CHAPTER 12 *Toward a Metaphysics of Custodial Witness*

CHAPTER 12

Toward a Metaphysics of Custodial Witness

The preceding chapters have assayed the corpus text by text. This chapter states the result as a system in seven articles and then meets the strongest objections. The system is McCarthy's only in the sense that his works compel it; it is mine in the sense that he never stated it. Its claim is that the corpus answers the problem of the fire with a single ethic, custodial witness, grounded in a single ontology and opposed to a single structural temptation.

12.1 *Ontology: One Fire, Two Principles*

Being is fire: a Heraclitean process of kindling and quenching in measures, governed by strife and conducted by exchange (Chapter 1). Violence is therefore ontological. It is not the failure of the cosmos but its grammar, and no politics, theology, or technology will abolish it; McCarthy's remark that there is no life without bloodshed is a metaphysical statement, not a temperament.

But the fire has two principles. Boehme's theosophy, which McCarthy cited at the threshold of *Blood Meridian*, holds that the same fire is wrath in the dark world and love in the light, and that the difference lies in a turning—the flash—rather than in two substances (Chapter 2). This is the corpus's decisive ontological claim, and it has been missed by every reading that asks whether McCarthy's world is good or evil, meaningful or void. The world is fire. The moral difference is not between fire and its absence but between two relations to the same fire. The judge and the boy are made of the same element.

12.2 *Anthropology: The Late Ember*

The human being is an animal run by an ancient unconscious and recently occupied by language (Chapter 10). The unconscious is the dark ground in its biological form: it has its own life, as Boehme said of the darkness; it solves problems, as it solved Kekulé's; it speaks in images; and it does not lie about the world. Language is the late ember—Promethean, stolen, powerful, and unstable. It makes possible the ledger and the law, the coin and the proof, the bomb and the tale.

Consciousness, on this account, is ouroboric. It is the loop by which a mind refers to itself, and self-reference is the formal structure of Gödel's sentence, of Hofstadter's strange loop, and of the serpent in Kekulé's dream. This is why McCarthy's most loquacious characters—the judge, Chigurh, White, Alicia—are the most endangered or the most dangerous: they are minds most fully occupied by the late fire, and most tempted by its closure. His least loquacious characters—the kid, Billy Parham, the boy—live nearer the ground, and it is from them that acts of custody come.

12.3 *Epistemology: Assay and Ledger*

To know is to assay by fire, and there are two pyrognostics.

The *proprietary* mode makes the known depend on the knower. Its paradigm is the judge's ledger, in which a thing is entered, seized, and destroyed so that it exists only in the record; its historical forms are the scalp bounty, the skull cabinet of *Crania Americana*, the Baconian identification of knowledge with power, and, at the end of the line, the physics that became the bomb. Its criterion is consent: nothing may exist without the knower's permission.

The *custodial* mode makes the knower answerable to the known. Its paradigms are Don Arnulfo's teaching that the wolf held is the wolf lost; the priest of Caborca's doctrine that acts have their being in the witness; the blind man's insistence that light belongs to the eye and not to the world; and the narrator's optical democracy, which grants every being the same attention. Its criterion is keeping: the known remains free, and the knower is responsible for it.

The two modes can be stated in the idiom of Berkeley, for whom to be is to be perceived and God is the perceiver who keeps things in being when no finite mind attends to them, and in that of John Archibald Wheeler, whose "participatory universe" (1990) made observation a condition of physical reality. The judge is a tyrant-observer, a usurper of Berkeley's God, who would make all existence conditional on his witness and destroy whatever escapes it. The priest's God is the custodial observer, who witnesses everything and owns nothing. Every McCarthyan narrative asks which observer governs it.

12.4 *Structure: Closure and Transmission*

The cosmos tends toward ouroboric closure: the ring that feeds on itself. Against closure the corpus sets transmission: the chain along which fire passes outward. The forms of each recur with a consistency that constitutes the corpus's deep structure.

DOMAIN	OUROBORIC CLOSURE	CATENARY TRANSMISSION
Kinship	Incest: Culla and Rinthy (OD); Bobby and Alicia (P, SM)	Exogamy: the boy received by another family (R)
Nourishment	Cannibalism: the triune (OD), the cellar and the spit (R)	The shared meal: the father and son; Black's supper for White (SL)
Love	Necrophilia: Ballard (CG)	Custody of the dead: Ownby (OK), the kid (BM), Billy (C), the boy (R)
Time	Recurrence: the judge's deathless dance (BM); the solar day (BM)	Generations: the closing verse of the trilogy (CP); the horn of fire (NC)
Knowledge	The ledger and the coin (BM, NC); self-reference (SM)	The tale: the priest's single tale, the corrido (C)
Cosmos	The outer darkness as serpent (OD; *Pistis Sophia*)	The breath passed from person to person through time (R)

The career is bracketed by closure—*Outer Dark* and the late diptych, both incest narratives; *Outer Dark* and "The Kekulé Problem," both ouroboroi—and every major work places at its centre an act of transmission that the ring cannot absorb.

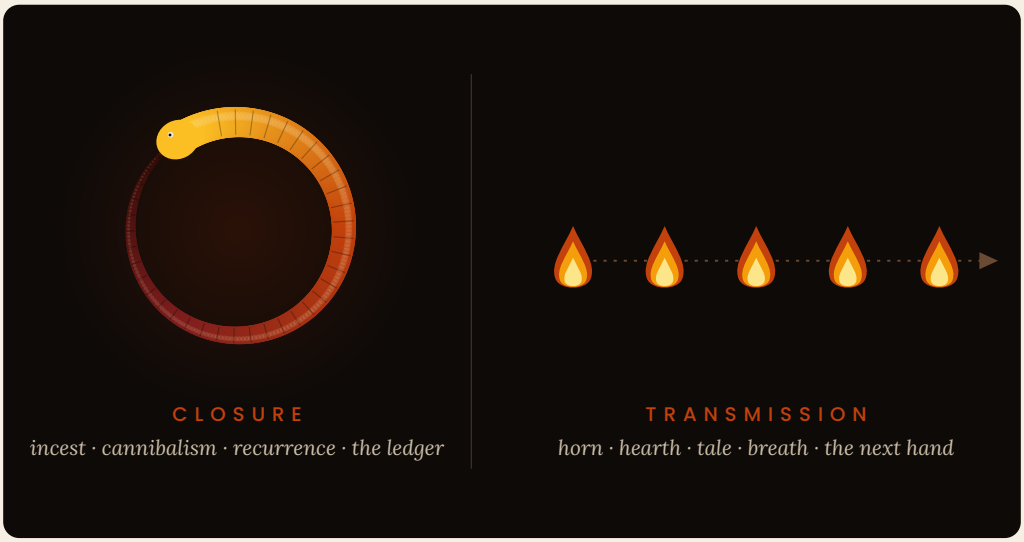


Figure 2. Ring and chain: the two structures of the corpus, ouroboric closure and catenary transmission.

12.5 *Ethics: Custodial Witness*

The Latin *custos* means a guard or keeper. McCarthy's first novel is named for one, and his work may be read as a sustained definition of what a keeper does. Custodial witness is the transmission of a fire under five conditions.

1. *The fire is not one's own.* The custodian did not kindle it: the father of *The Road* carries a fire that predates him, and Bell's father carries fire in a horn, the way people used to.
2. *The fire cannot be justified.* No ground underwrites it. The father cannot answer the boy's questions about why they go on, and the corpus nowhere supplies an answer on his behalf.
3. *The witness may not exist.* The addressee of custody is uncertain—God, the future, a reader. Black pleads with a God who does not reply; the trilogy's verse addresses a reader it cannot see; Shelley's last man sails with his books for no one.
4. *The fire goes outward.* Custody is lateral and exogamous. It is fulfilled when the fire passes to another hand, as the boy passes into another family and the breath of God passes from person to person.
5. *The dead are included.* Custody extends to what can no longer be helped: the orchard keeper's vigil, the kid's offer to the long-dead woman, the wolf's burial, Boyd's bones, the boy's three days beside his father.

The ethic has a philosophical lineage that McCarthy does not cite but that his fiction corroborates. Simone Weil wrote in 1942 that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity; the narrator's optical democracy is attention as a narrative discipline. Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totality and Infinity* (1961), located ethics in a responsibility for the other that precedes freedom and cannot be chosen; the boy's pity for the thief and the kid's clemency are such responsibility, unchosen and inexplicable. Hannah Arendt's natality supplies the father's hope. Dostoevsky's Zosima, who taught that each of us is responsible for all, supplies the boy's insistence that he is the one who must worry about everything. And Hestia, as Vernant described her, supplies the ethic its patron: the hearth that keeps a centre in a world of passage.

Against custodial witness stand its three counterfeits: *proprietary witness* (the judge), which keeps by seizing; *abdicated witness* (Chigurh), which kills while disowning the decision; and *refused witness* (Culla Holme, the young Bell, Billy with the dog), which will not see. The corpus's ethics is the anatomy of these four postures.

12.6 *Politics: Nomos, Fence, and Fireball*

McCarthy has no programme, but he has a diagnosis. The political history of the corpus is the history of proprietary pyrognosis becoming sovereignty. Its first act is the scalp contract, in which the state purchases dead bodies by the piece and so defines a class of persons who, in Giorgio Agamben's terms (1995), may be killed without either crime or sacrifice. Its second is the epilogue's line of post holes, the *nomos* of the earth in Schmitt's sense, by which land-appropriation founds legal order and the frontier closes. Its third is the army's taking of the ranch lands in *Cities of the Plain* for its weapons ranges. Its fourth is Trinity, the fire in which sovereignty became capable of deciding on the existence of cities—a capacity the United States exercised three weeks later on Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception; the bomb is the exception made permanent, and the agents who pursue Bobby Western in 1980 are its bureaucracy.

The myths the corpus dismantles are the myths of this history: John O'Sullivan's manifest destiny (1845), the regeneration through violence that Slotkin anatomized, and Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier as the forge of democratic character. McCarthy replaces them with a single image. The West did not advance toward a new morning; it advanced toward an evening that it finally lit with its own fire.

12.7 *Aesthetics: The Tale as Hearth*

The fire is where tales are told. Polly Wiessner's fieldwork among the Ju/'hoansi (2014) found that talk by day concerned economic matters and complaint, while talk by firelight was overwhelmingly given to stories; the hearth, on this evidence, is the native site of narrative. McCarthy's fiction is full of campfires—the gang's tales and the judge's lectures, the tales told to Billy Parham, the father's stories to his son—and the relation is reciprocal. The fire makes narration possible, and narration is how fire is carried.

The tale is therefore the last hearth. The priest of Caborca holds that the world is a single tale; the corrido carries Boyd Parham; Bulgakov's Woland declares that manuscripts do not burn. And the corpus conscripts its reader into the witness it requires. *Blood Meridian* begins with an imperative to see the child. *Child of God* addresses its necrophile to the reader as one of God's children, much like the reader. The Border Trilogy ends by asking the reader to turn the page. The novel is the horn in which the ember is carried, and the reader is the one who arrives to find the fire already made.

12.8 *Objections and Replies*

The nihilist objection. Custody is a sentimental projection onto texts that deny all value. *Reply:* The denial of ground is granted in full; the thesis requires it. But the texts dignify acts of custody with their most sustained attention and place them at their structural centres. Custody is not grounded; it is enacted, and the enactment is what the novels record.

The Gnostic objection. A spark implies an elsewhere to which it belongs. *Reply:* The spark in McCarthy is never returned; its only motion is lateral. The Gnostic topology survives; the Gnostic destination does not.

The sacramental objection. Custody is simply sacrament under another name. *Reply:* Sacrament requires an instituting community and an efficacious grace, and the corpus supplies neither. Custody is sub-sacramental: a rite of the hearth rather than the altar. The sacramental reading remains this thesis's nearest ally.

The naturalist objection. Optical democracy forbids any moral privilege. *Reply:* Equity is itself an ethical discipline. Weil saw in the *Iliad*'s impartiality not indifference but the only truthful account of force. Flatness is attention.

The feminist objection. The transmission of fire in McCarthy is overwhelmingly patrilineal—father to son, man to man—and women appear chiefly as victims, prizes, or absences; Nell Sullivan (2000) has traced the circuit of male desire in the Border Trilogy in these terms. *Reply:* The objection is substantially correct, and it marks a real limit of the corpus. The fire passes most often between men. Yet the counter-figures are not negligible: Rinthy Holme, whose body continues

the custody her brother refused; Carla Jean Moss, who alone unmasks the coin; Betty, who takes in old Billy Parham; the woman at the end of *The Road*, who speaks the corpus's most explicit theology of transmission; and Alicia Western, the most brilliant mind in all of McCarthy, to whom his final book is wholly given. The late turn to a woman's consciousness is the corpus's belated acknowledgement of what its fire had excluded, and a pyrognostic reading should register the exclusion as part of the assay.

CONCLUSION

The Snake and the Ember

McCarthy's work is governed by two figures: a serpent that devours its own tail and an ember carried in a horn. This dissertation has argued that the whole corpus—eleven novels, two plays, two screenplays, and a late essay on the origin of language—can be read as the contest between them.

The serpent is closure. It encircles the world as the outer darkness of the *Pistis Sophia* and names McCarthy's second novel. It feeds on its young in that novel's last pages, and on the species in the cellars of *The Road*. It is the endogamous ring of incest, the necrophile's love turned toward what cannot refuse, the judge's dance of recurrence, the solar day of *Blood Meridian* that returns to its dawn only to begin the fences. It is the ledger that seizes everything and the coin that disowns its own decisions. It is the self-reference of Gödel's sentence and of the mind that Alicia Western could not ground from within. In its most abstract form it is sovereignty itself: a knowing that makes the known depend on the knower, which begins in the scalp contract and ends in the fire at Trinity.

The ember is transmission. It is the orchard keeper's vigil over a stranger's body, the kid's absurd offer to a woman dead for years, Billy Parham's rifle traded for a wolf he can only bury, a jug of water carried back through the night to a dying man. It is the horn of fire in which a dead father goes ahead to make a hearth in the cold, and the fire a living father and son carry south along a road of ash. It is a breath of God that passes from one person to another through all of time, a corrido, a manuscript that does not burn, and the four couplets in which the Border Trilogy pledges that the child held now will one day hold the old.

The serpent and the ember are made of the same fire. That is the lesson of Heraclitus, for whom one ever-living fire kindles and quenches the world in measure, and of Boehme, whose epigraph opens *Blood Meridian* and for whom the same fire is wrath in the darkness and love in the light. It is why McCarthy is neither the nihilist of his first critics nor the Gnostic of his most learned ones. He grants the nihilist that the fire has no ground, and the Gnostic that something in it is foreign to the world. But he denies both the conclusion they draw. The absence of ground does not make custody meaningless; it makes custody the

only meaning available. The foreignness of the spark does not send it upward to a pleroma; it sends it sideways, to the next hand.

"The Kekulé Problem" allows a final turn. Kekulé, dozing by his fire, saw the serpent seize its tail and woke with the structure of the benzene ring. The image of closure solved the problem of the ring. The unconscious—the dark ground whose life, Boehme said, is not sorrowing—delivered it as a picture to a man at his hearth. The snake, then, is not only a trap. It is also a key, on one condition: that someone see it. To witness the ring is already to stand, however briefly, outside it. That is what McCarthy's narrating voice does when it looks with equal attention on the massacre and the mesa, and it is what his novels require of their readers when they begin with an imperative to see the child.

The corpus ends where *The Road* ends, with the trout. Once, the narrator says, there were fish in the mountain streams whose backs bore patterns that were maps of the world in its becoming, of a thing that could not be put back or made right again. The maps are pyrognostic cartographies: patterns laid down by the fire of becoming, in a world older than any witness and indifferent to all of them. McCarthy does not promise that the world can be restored. He shows that it was once seen, and that its seeing can be kept.

The fire was never ours. That is why it can be carried.

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PYROGNOSIS